

Italian, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Italian one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart — traced back to its root (usually Latin), then forward to the English cousins you already own, so nothing here is a fresh thing to memorise. It is written for someone starting from zero, whose only shared language is English. *grazie* (“thanks”) turns out to be English *grace*; *giorno* (“day”) is the *journ-* of *journal* and *journey*; and *ciao*, the most famous “hello” in the world, once meant “I am your slave.”

Italian is the closest living child of Latin, so its words often wear their roots most plainly of the Romance languages. Where a sister language (Spanish or French, the other daughters of Latin) makes the contrast vivid, the book shows it — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of them is assumed; a reader who happens to know one simply nods along.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Italian out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Italian greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” the day-parts, the article that carries gender, and the most famous “hello” in the world. Each word is taken apart to its root and its English cousins. *Practice lessons: lessons/IT-C01-*.md.*

1.1 *ciao* — “hi,” and the word that means “I am your slave”

Sounds you’ll need

CHOW — *ci* before a vowel is the *ch* of *church*, and *-ao* is one gliding syllable, like the English *ciao* you may already have heard.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ciao began as the Venetian greeting *s-ciào (vostro)* — “[I am your] slave / servant,” a humble “at your service.” That *s-ciào* is Venetian for *schiaivo* (“slave”) ← Medieval Latin *sclavus*. The very same word is English **slave** — and, astonishingly, **Slav**: medieval slaves were so often Slavic captives that the ethnic name *became* the word for “slave” across Europe. So every casual *ciao* is a fossil of “I am your servant,” carrying the buried history of a whole people.

Why it’s said this way

ciao is **informal**, and works both coming and going (“hi” and “bye”) — for friends, family, peers. To someone you’d show respect, or on a first meeting, you reach instead for *buongiorno*, built over the next lessons.

(Doubled, *ciao ciao*, it's a breezy “bye-bye.”)

1.2 *buono* / *buon* — “good”

Sounds you'll need

buono = *BWOH-no*; the *uo* is a glide. Before a masculine noun it clips to **buon** (*bwon*) — *buon giorno*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buono (“good”) ← Latin *bonus* → English **bonus**, **bonanza**, **bonbon**, and (through French) **bounty**. Spanish, another daughter of Latin, made the same *bonus* into *bueno*; Italian kept it closer, *buono*.

Grammar Lens

buono **agrees** with its noun in gender and number — *buono* (m.), *buona* (f.), *buoni* / *buone* (pl.). This gender-agreement of adjectives is Latin's legacy across the Romance family. Before a masculine noun *buono* drops its *-o* to *buon*: you'll see it in *buon giorno*.

1.3 *il* / *la* / *lo* — “the,” and the gender it carries

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

il and **lo** (masculine “the”) and **la** (feminine) ← Latin *ille* / *illa* (“that one”), the pointing word worn down to “the.” The same *ille/illa* gave Spanish *el/la* and French *le/la* — and also Italian **lui/lei** (“he/she”). (English “the” is Germanic, unrelated.)

Grammar Lens

Every Italian noun is masculine or feminine — Latin's three genders (the neuter folded mostly into the masculine) collapsed to two. Learn each noun *with* its article. Italian has *two* masculine “the”s: **lo** before tricky clusters (*lo studente*, *lo zio*) and **il** everywhere else (*il giorno*); feminine is always *la*. Don't drill the rule — just meet *il* at the first noun, next.

1.4 *giorno* — “day,” and the road to English *journey*

Sounds you’ll need

gi = the *j* of *jam*; *gior-no* = *JOR-no*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

il giorno (masc.) ← Latin *diurnum* (“daytime”), from *dies* (“day”). That detour through *diurnum* is why *giorno* looks nothing like Latin *dies*: cousins are **j**ournal, ad**j**ourn, so**j**ourn, and **j**ourney (a *day’s* travel) — all from the same *diurnum* — plus **di**urnal and **di**ary straight from *dies*. Italian *giorno* and French *jour* are near-twins here; Spanish, taking *dies* directly, got the very different *día*.

Grammar Lens

giorno is **masculine** (*il giorno*). Plural *i giorni* — Italian marks the plural by changing the final vowel (*-o* → *-i*), not by adding *-s*.

1.5 *buongiorno* — “good day,” assembled

buon (“good”) + *giorno* (“day”) = **buongiorno**, “good day,” one word — the polite, all-purpose daytime hello.

Why it’s said this way

Where the casual *ciao* says “I’m your servant,” *buongiorno* simply wishes you a good day — and it is the **safe, respectful** choice with anyone: shopkeepers, strangers, elders. Used through the day until late afternoon, when it gives way to *buonasera*.

1.6 *sera* — “evening,” and *buonasera*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sera (fem.) ← Latin *sera* (“late [hour]”), from *serus*, “late.” English cousin: the rare *serotine* (a bat of the *late* evening). **buonasera** = *buona* + *sera*, “good evening” — *buona* in its feminine form, because *sera* is feminine.

1.7 *notte* — “night,” and the *-ct-* → *-tt-* rule

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la notte (fem.) ← Latin *noctem* (*noct-*) → **nocturnal**, **equinox**. The change is a *rule*: Latin *-ct-* became Italian **-tt-** (*notte*), where Spanish softened it to *-ch-* (*noche*) and French to *-it-* (*nuit*).

Latin	Italian	Spanish	French	English
<i>noctem</i>	<i>notte</i>	<i>noche</i>	<i>nuit</i>	night
<i>lactem</i>	<i>latte</i>	<i>leche</i>	<i>lait</i>	(lact-)
<i>factum</i>	<i>fatto</i>	<i>hecho</i>	<i>fait</i>	fact

buonanotte = *buona* + *notte*, “good night” — the farewell for bed (not an evening hello; that’s *buonasera*).

1.8 *grazie* — “thank you,” from *grace*

Sounds you’ll need

GRAH-tsyeH — **z** in Italian is *ts*; the final *-e* is sounded (two syllables in *-zie*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

grazie (“thanks”) ← Latin *gratiæ*, plural of *gratia* (“favour, thanks, grace”). It is the *same* *gratia* behind English **grace**, **gratitude**, **grateful**, **gratis** (“free”), **congratulate**, and **ingratiate**. So *grazie* literally offers someone *grace*. (Reply: *prego*, “you’re welcome” — literally “I pray [it’s nothing].”)

1.9 The day of greetings

Italian	English
<i>ciao</i>	hi / bye (informal)
<i>buongiorno</i>	good day
<i>buonasera</i>	good evening
<i>buonanotte</i>	good night
<i>grazie</i>	thank you

Every piece from a Latin root: *ciao* (*sclavus*, “slave”), *buono* (*bonus*), *giorno* (*diurnum*), *notte* (*noctem*, via the *-ct-→-tt-* rule), *grazie* (*gratia*, “grace”). Next chapter: introducing yourself — *mi chiamo...* (“my name is...”) — and Italian’s *tu* vs. *Lei* (familiar / formal “you”).

Chapter 2

How Are You?

2.1 *prego* — “you’re welcome,” literally “I pray”

The *grazie* lesson already promised you this word. Someone says **grazie**; you reply **prego**. Like German *bitte*, it’s a small word that does several jobs — and it comes straight from **praying**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **hard-g-before-o** — **prego** = *PREH-go* with a **hard g**. (Italian *g* is soft only before *e/i*; here the *g* is followed by *o*, so it stays hard.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

prego is “I pray” — the *io* (“I”) form of **pregare**, “to pray, to beg,” from Latin **precārī**. When you answer *grazie* with *prego*, you’re softly saying “*I pray (it was nothing) / please, don’t mention it.*”

That root **prec-** (“pray, entreat”) gives English a surprising family:

- **pray, prayer** — the direct line.
- **precarious** — literally “held by *prayer*,” i.e. depending on someone’s goodwill, therefore unstable.
- **deprecate** (“pray *away*, ward off”) and **imprecation** (“a prayer *against* — a curse”).

Like German **bitte**, *prego* stretches across situations, all of them a form of “I pray you”:

you say <i>prego</i> when...	it means
answering <i>grazie</i>	you're welcome
offering a seat / letting someone pass	please, go ahead / after you
handing something over	here you are
you didn't catch it	sorry, come again?

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “grazie” ... “prego” — the full exchange
- “prego” then English “pray, precarious” — one family

Before you move on

What verb is *prego* the “I” form of? (*pregare*, “to pray.”) What English word means “held by prayer” and so “unstable”? (*Precarious*.) Which German word does *prego* behave like? (*bitte* — one word, many courtesies.) Next: **come**, “how.”

2.2 come — “how,” the third *quomodo* cousin

To ask *how are you?* you need “how.” In Italian it’s **come** — and if you’ve seen the Spanish or French tracks, you already know its family.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — **come** = *KOH-meh*. Here *c* is before *o*, so it’s a **hard k** (Italian *c* only softens to *ch* before *e/i*). Final *-e* is sounded: *KOH-meh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

come = “how / like / as.” Root: Latin **quōmodo**, “in what manner” — two words (*quō* “in what way” + *modo* “manner”) fused and worn down. It is the **same source** as:

- Spanish **cómo** (“how”)
- French **comment** (“how”)
- and, doubling as “like/as,” it matches Spanish **como** and French **comme**.

So one Latin *quōmodo* became the “how” word in all three Romance sisters. The *modo* piece (“manner, measure”) also lives in English **mode**, **model**, **moderate** — all about the *way* something is done. Note Italian *come* covers **both** jobs at once, and the written accent tells them apart only by context, not spelling: *Come stai?* (“**H**ow are you?”) vs *bianco come la neve* (“white **a**s snow”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “come” — *KOH-meh*
- come / cómo / comment — the three *quomodo* siblings
- English *mode*, *model* share the *modo* piece

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *come*, and which Spanish and French words are its siblings? (*quōmodo* → *cómo*, *comment*.) What two jobs does *come* do? (“How?” and “like/as.”) Next: the verb it pairs with — **stare**.

2.3 stare — “to be,” the standing kind (Spanish’s *estar*, undressed)

Like Spanish, Italian has **two** verbs for “to be” — **essere** (identity) and **stare** (state). “How are you?” runs on **stare**. And if you did the Spanish track, this is *estar* with its front *e* taken off.

Sounds you'll need

- **st-clean** — Italian, unlike Spanish, is happy to start a word with *st-*: no propping *e*. **stare** = *STAH-reh*, clean *st*, final *-e* sounded.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

stare comes straight from Latin **stāre**, “to stand.” Spanish grew the same verb into **estar** (with a propping *e-*); Italian kept it bare as **stare**. Same Latin root, same job: the *temporary state* be-verb — how you *stand* right now.

That **stā-** root stands behind a wall of English words: **stay**, **stand**, **state**, **status**, **stable**, **station**, **stance**, **e-state**, **con-stant**, **circum-stance**. So *Come stai?* is, at the root, “how do you stand?” — the very same picture as Spanish *¿Cómo estás?*

Grammar Lens: essere vs stare, and the two forms you need

verb	from	job
essere	Latin <i>esse</i>	identity — <i>sono Marco</i> , “I am Marco”
stare	Latin <i>stāre</i>	state / how you are — <i>sto bene</i> , “I’m well”

For this chapter, just two forms of *stare*:

- **stai** — “you are” (informal, *tu*)
- **sta** — “you are” (formal, *Lei*) / “he/she is”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “stare” — *STAH-reh*, clean *st*
- “stai” ... “sta” — the two forms you’ll ask with
- Italian *stare* = Spanish *estar*, same Latin *stāre* “to stand”

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *stare*, and which Spanish verb is its twin? (“To stand,” *stāre* — Spanish *estar*.) Which Italian be-verb is for how you feel — *essere* or *stare*? (*stare*.) Next: ask it — **Come stai?**

2.4 Come stai? — “how are you?”

Both pieces are ready: **come** (“how”) and **stare** / **stai** (“to be,” from *stand*). Assemble Italian’s everyday question for a friend.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Come stai? = “How are you?” (informal) literally: “**How do you stand?**”

- **come** = “how”
- **stai** = “you are / stand,” the *tu* form of *stare*

The subject **tu** (“you”) is already carried by **stai**, so Italian normally leaves it unspoken. Say **Come stai?**, not *Come tu stai?*, unless you need to stress “you.” This is the same pro-drop habit you will use in later verb lessons.

An everyday answer reuses the same verb:

Come stai? — Sto bene, grazie. “How are you? — I’m well, thanks.”

Sto means “I am / stand.” The pair **stai** / **sto** lets the ending do the pronoun’s work: “you” in *-ai*, “I” in *-o*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Come stai?” — informal, for a friend
- “Sto bene, grazie.”
- the two-part exchange — “Come stai? — Sto bene.”

Twice through: “Come stai? — Sto bene, grazie.”

Before you move on

Come stai? literally asks what? (“How do you **stand**?”) Which word means “how”? (**Come**.) Which form answers “I am”? (**Sto**.) Give the whole exchange: **Come stai? — Sto bene, grazie.** Next: formal speech and the “go” version.

2.5 Come sta? — the formal question

You can ask a friend **Come stai?** Change one ending when you speak to a stranger or elder.

Grammar Lens: stai and sta

Come sta? = “How are you?” (formal)

Italian uses **Lei** — literally “she,” often capitalized — as a polite “you.” Its verb therefore uses the third-person form **sta**, not informal **stai**:

listener	question
a friend (<i>tu</i>)	Come stai?
a stranger or elder (<i>Lei</i>)	Come sta?

The politeness pattern has cousins in Spanish *usted* and German *Sie*, but you only need one Italian contrast here: **stai** for a friend, **sta** for formal respect.

An answer can return the formal pronoun:

Bene, grazie. E Lei? — “Well, thank you. And you?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a friend — “Come stai?”
- to a stranger — “Come sta?”
- “Bene, grazie. E Lei?”

Twice through: “Stai — friend. Sta — formal.”

Before you move on

Which ending marks a friend? (**-i: stai.**) Which form is formal? (**Sta.**) What polite pronoun can follow *e*, “and”? (**Lei.**) Next: keep the meaning but switch the picture from “stand” to “go.”

2.6 Come va? — “how is it going?”

Come stai? pictures wellbeing as standing. Italian also has the same “going” picture as English.

Come va? = “How’s it going?”

Va comes from **andare**, “to go.” Unlike *stai* / *sta*, this question does not force you to choose an informal or formal ending, so it is useful in either setting.

Grammar Lens: standing and going

- **Come stai?** — “How do you **stand**?”
- **Come va?** — “How does it **go**?”

Spanish also uses the “stand” picture in *¿cómo estás?*; French and German use a “go” picture. Italian keeps **both**, which makes it a bridge between them. The comparison is only a memory aid: in Italian, simply connect **stai** with *stare* and **va** with *andare*.

You will learn all six forms of *andare* much later. For now, **va** is one ready-made piece inside this question.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the standing question — “Come stai?”
- the going question — “Come va?”
- “Come va? — Bene, grazie.”

Twice through: “Come stai? — Come va?”

Before you move on

Which question uses “stand”? (**Come stai?**) Which uses “go”? (**Come va?**) What infinitive owns **va**? (**Andare.**) Must *Come va?* choose between *tu* and *Lei*? (**No.**) Next: answer with the original Italian “so-so.”

2.7 *così così* — the original “so-so”

English “so-so” is a **loan translation of the Italian** *così così*. Someone asks *Come stai?*; you’re middling; you wobble a hand and say *così così* — “thus and thus,” this way and that.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — **così** = *koh-ZEE*: the *c* is before *o* (hard *k*), and the single *s* between vowels is **voiced**, a *z* sound: *koh-ZEE*. Stress the end (that’s what the accent on *ì* marks).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

così = “thus, so, in this way,” from Latin **(ec)cum sīc**, “(behold) so.” Doubled — *così così* — it means “**so** and **so**,” neither up nor down: a verbal shrug.

The core piece **sīc** (“thus, so”) is one you already write in English:

- **sic** — the *[sic]* you put after a quoted mistake means “**thus** it was written.”
- It’s also the Latin behind Spanish/French/Italian **sì** / **si** / **sì** (“yes” — “it is *so*”), and the *-si* inside French **ain-si** (“thus”).

So *così così* is literally “**so, so**” — and English simply borrowed the shrug whole.

Grammar Lens: your answer ladder for *Come stai?*

answer	sense
(Molto) bene, grazie	(very) well, thanks
Così così	so-so
Non c'è male	“not bad” (lit. “there isn’t bad”)

The cross-track shrug set, now five deep: Italian **così così** (“so, so”), French **comme ci comme ça** (“like this, like that”), Spanish **más o menos** (“more or less”), German **es geht** (“it goes”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “così così” — *koh-ZEE koh-ZEE*, with a hand-wobble
- answer “Come stai?” three ways — “Bene” / “Così così” / “Non c’è male”
- “sic” in English — “thus” — the same *sīc*

Before you move on

What does *così così* literally mean? (“Thus, thus / so, so.”) What Latin word for “so” is inside it, and where do you still write it in English? (*sīc* → [*sic*].) English “so-so” came from — which language? (Italian *così così*.) Next: put the exchange together.

2.8 Practice — “Come stai?”, start to finish

No new words. This chapter’s atoms — *prego, come, stare, come stai?, così così* — assemble into a real exchange, formal and informal. It picks up from the Chapter 1 greetings.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder — *Lei*):

— Buongiorno. **Come sta?** — **Bene, grazie.** E Lei? — **Così così.** — [after a small favour] — **Grazie!** — **Prego.**

Informal (a friend — *tu*):

— Ciao! **Come stai?** — **Sto bene, e tu?** — Non c'è male.

The glue is **e Lei?** / **e tu?** — “and you?” (*e* = “and,” Latin *et*) — the Italian twin of Spanish *¿y usted?* and French *et toi?*.

What you've built this chapter

- **prego** — you're welcome / please (← *pregare*, “to pray”; English *precarious*).
- **come** — how (← *quōmodo*; sibling of *cómo* / *comment*).
- **stare** — “to be” from *stand* (= Spanish *estar*); vs *essere* (identity).
- **Come stai?** / **sta?** / **va?** — informal, formal, and the “how's it going?” form (*va* ← *andare*, “to go”).
- **così così** — so-so (English “so-so” borrowed it whole).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both voices
- the same *informally* — *sta* → *stai*, *Lei* → *tu*
- all three questions — *Come stai?* / *Come sta?* / *Come va?*

Twice through: “*Come stai?* — *Sto bene, grazie, e tu?*” until it's reflex.

Before you move on

Which verb carries *Come stai?*, and what does it literally ask? (*stare*, “to stand” — “how do you stand?”) What does *prego* answer, and from what root? (*grazie*; ← *pregare*, “to pray.”) Italian can ask “how are you” two ways — which verbs? (*stare*, stand; *andare* → *va*, go.) Next chapter: **introducing yourself** — *mi chiamo, come ti chiami*.

Chapter 3

Introducing Yourself

3.1 io — “I,” the pronoun Italian loves to leave out

Before you introduce yourself, meet **io** — “I.” It’s a small word with a famous English cousin, and a surprising habit: Italian usually **drops it**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **io-glide** — **io** = *EE-oh*, two quick vowels gliding together, stress the first: *EE-oh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

io = “I,” worn down from Latin **ego** — which English borrowed *whole*:

- **ego** — literally Latin “I” (your sense of self).
- **egoist**, **egotist**, **egocentric** — all built on that “I.”
- Its Romance siblings: Spanish **yo**, Portuguese **eu**, French **je** — every one a child of *ego*.

Grammar Lens: the dropped subject (pro-drop)

Here’s the Italian habit worth learning now: **the verb ending already tells you who’s speaking, so the pronoun is usually left out**. *Sto bene* (“I’m well”) needs no *io* — the *-o* of *sto* is “I.” You add **io** only for **emphasis** or **contrast**:

Io sto bene — e tu? — “I’m fine — and you?”

Spanish (*yo*) and Portuguese (*eu*) do exactly the same. English can’t: it must say “I” every time. So learning Italian means learning to *trust the verb ending* and let the pronoun go.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “io” — *EE-oh*
- “io” then English “ego, egoist” — the same Latin “I”
- “Sto bene” with no *io* — the ending carries the “I”

Before you move on

What Latin word is *io* from, and what English words share it? (*Ego* — ego, egoist.) Why does Italian usually drop *io*? (The verb ending already says who.) When do you keep it? (For emphasis/contrast.) Next: use it to introduce yourself — **mi chiamo**.

3.2 mi chiamo — “I call myself”

Like Spanish and French, Italian doesn’t say “my name is.” It says “**I call myself**” — **mi chiamo**. Same reflexive trick, same *clāmāre* root as Spanish *me llamo*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **ch-hard-k** — Italian **ch** is a **hard k** (the opposite of English!): so **chiamo** = *KYAH-moh*, not “chee-.” (Italian softens *c* to *ch*-sound only before *e/i*; the *h* in *chi* is there precisely to keep it hard.)
- **mi chiamo** = *mee KYAH-moh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mi chiamo = **mi** (“myself”) + **chiamo** (“I call”) → “**I call myself.**”

Then the name: *Mi chiamo Marco* — “I call myself Marco.”

The verb is **chiamarsi** (“to call oneself”), from Latin **clāmāre**, “*to cry out, to call.*” That root shouts through English:

- **claim, exclaim, proclaim, acclaim, clamor** — all “calling out.”
- Its Romance siblings all name people the same way: Spanish **llamarse** (*me llamo*), Portuguese **chamar-se** (*me chamo*) — the *cl-* softening to *ll-* (Spanish) or *ch-* (Italian/Portuguese). One Latin “call,” three naming verbs.

Grammar Lens: the reflexive, and the dropping of *io*

chiamo alone is “I call [someone else]”; **mi chiamo** is “I call **myself**” — **reflexive**, the action looping back on you. The pronoun changes with the person: **mi** chiamo (I) → **ti** chiami (you) → **si** chiama (he/she/formal). And notice: no *io* — the *-o* ending already says “I.” (You met that pro-drop last lesson.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mi chiamo” — *mee KYAH-moh*, hard *k* in *chiamo*
- “Mi chiamo ...” with your own name
- “chiamo” then English “claim, exclaim, clamor” — the *clāmāre* family

Before you move on

What does *mi chiamo* literally mean? (“I call myself.”) What Latin verb is *chiamarsi* from, and its English cousins? (*clāmāre* — claim, exclaim, clamor.) How is Italian *ch* pronounced? (A hard *k*.) Next: ask it back — **Come ti chiami?**

3.3 Come ti chiami? — “what’s your name?”

You have both pieces: **come** (“how,” from your how-are-you chapter) and **chiamarsi** (“to call oneself”). Like Spanish and French, Italian asks the name with “**how**”, not “what”: *how do you call yourself?*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Come ti chiami? = “What’s your name?” (informal) literally: “**How do you call yourself?**”

- **come** = “how” (← *quōmodo*; you met it in *Come stai?*).
- **ti** = “yourself” (the reflexive, matching *mi* → *ti*).
- **chiami** = “you call” (the *tu* form of *chiamarsi*).

Two registers — the same *tu* / *Lei* split you learned in Chapter 2:

register	question
informal (<i>tu</i>)	Come ti chiami?
formal (<i>Lei</i>)	Come si chiama?

Only the reflexive pronoun and the ending move: *ti chiami* → *si chiama* — the identical pattern to *mi chiamo* → *si chiama*. The whole exchange:

— Come ti chiami? — Mi chiamo Marco. E tu?

Note Italian asks the name with *come* (“how”), exactly like Spanish *¿cómo se llama?* and French *comment vous appelez-vous?* — the name is a matter of *how* you’re called, not *what* you are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Come ti chiami?” — informal, for a peer
- “Come si chiama?” — formal, for a stranger (*Lei*)
- the whole swap — “Come ti chiami? — Mi chiamo ... E tu?”

Before you move on

What does *Come ti chiami?* literally ask? (“How do you call yourself?”) What changes for the formal *Lei* version? (*ti chiami* → *si chiama*.) Which “how” word is it built on? (*come* ← *quōmodo*.) Next: the reply when you meet — **piacere**.

3.4 piacere — “pleased to meet you,” i.e. “a pleasure”

Names exchanged, you close the introduction with one warm word: **piacere** — literally “a pleasure.” It’s the twin of a word you’d say in Portuguese, and it’s pure Latin *please*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — **piacere** = *pya-CHEH-reh*: here *c* is before *e*, so it’s soft (*ch*), and the *ia* glides: *pya-CHE-re*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

piacere = “a pleasure” (and, as a verb, “to please”), from Latin **placēre**, “to please, to be pleasing.” Said on meeting someone, it’s short for “[it’s] a pleasure [to meet you].”

That **placēre** root is thoroughly at home in English:

- **please, pleasure, pleasant** — the direct line.
- **complacent** (“pleased *with* oneself”), **complaisant**, **placid** (pleased → calm).

And across the family, “pleased to meet you” is built from the *same* idea nearly everywhere:

- Portuguese **prazer** (← *placēre* too — its twin).
- French **enchanté** (a different image — “enchanted”).
- Spanish **mucho gusto** (“much pleasure,” but from *gustus*, “taste” — a different Latin root).

Grammar Lens: a one-word courtesy

Piacere stands alone — you just say it, with a small nod, as you shake hands. For a touch more you can say *molto piacere* (“much pleasure”) or *piacere di conoscerti* (“pleasure to know you”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “piacere” — *pya-CHEH-reh*
- “piacere” then English “please, pleasure, placid” — the *placēre* root
- Italian *piacere* and Portuguese *prazer* — twins from *placēre*

Before you move on

What does *piacere* literally mean, and from what? (“A pleasure,” ← *placēre* “to please.”) Its English cousins? (Please, pleasure, placid, complacent.) Which Portuguese word is its twin? (*Prazer*.) Next: put the whole introduction together.

3.5 Practice — introducing yourself in Italian

No new words. *io, mi chiamo, come ti chiami, piacere* now assemble into a real first meeting — run it formally and informally until the register swap is automatic. This slots between your greetings (Ch. 1–2) and farewells (Ch. 4).

The exchange

Informal (a peer):

— Ciao! **Come ti chiami?** — **Mi chiamo** Marco. E tu? —
Giulia. **Piacere!** — Piacere!

Formal (a stranger — *Lei*):

— Buongiorno. **Come si chiama?** — Mi chiamo Marco Rossi.
E Lei? — Rossi. **Molto piacere.**

What you've built this chapter

- **io** — “I” (← *ego*), usually **dropped** — the verb ending carries it.
- **mi chiamo** — “I call myself” (*chiamarsi* ← *clāmāre*, “call out”; kin of Spanish *me llamo*, Portuguese *me chamo*).
- **Come ti chiami?** / **Come si chiama?** — “how do you call yourself?”, informal / formal.
- **piacere** — “a pleasure” (← *placēre*; twin of Portuguese *prazer*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full informal meeting, both voices
- the same formally — *ti chiami* → *si chiama*, *tu* → *Lei*
- chain it all — greet, name, ask, how-are-you, goodbye: “Ciao! Mi chiamo ... Come ti chiami? ... Come stai? ... A domani!”

Twice through: Run a whole first meeting start to finish.

Before you move on

Why does Italian usually drop *io*? (The verb ending says who.) What does *mi chiamo* literally mean, and its root? (“I call myself”; *clāmāre*.) What does *piacere* mean? (“A pleasure.”) Italian now runs greet → introduce → how-are-you → goodbye, end to end.

Chapter 4

Farewells

4.1 arrivederci — “goodbye,” i.e. “until we meet again”

You can open a conversation in Italian and ask how someone is. Now, close it. The standard goodbye is **arrivederci** — and, like its French and German cousins, it doesn’t say “goodbye” at all. It says “**until we see each other again.**”

Sounds you’ll need

- **arrivederci** = *ar-ree-veh-**DER**-chee*: a tapped double *r*, and the final *-ci* is soft (*chee*, Italian *c* before *i*). Stress the *-der-*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Break it into four pieces you can almost read straight off:

- **a** = “to / until” (Latin *ad*).
- **ri-** = “again” (Latin *re-* — as in English *re-do*, *re-view*).
- **vedere** = “to see” (Latin *vidēre* → English **video**, **vision**, **evident**, **provide**).
- **-ci** = “us / each other.”

Glued: *a-(ri)-vedere-ci* → “**to our seeing-one-another-again.**” You don’t say farewell; you promise the next meeting.

The whole family says the same thing

This “until re-seeing” idea is shared right across the languages you’re learning — a lovely thing to notice:

language	goodbye	literally
Italian	<i>arrivederci</i>	“to our re-seeing”
French	<i>au revoir</i>	“to the re-seeing” (<i>re</i> + <i>voir</i> , see)
German	<i>auf Wiedersehen</i>	“on again-seeing” (<i>wieder</i> + <i>sehen</i>)

Three languages, one gesture: part by pointing at the reunion, not the parting. (Italian keeps a heavier, final “to God” goodbye too — **addio**, *a Dio* — the exact twin of Spanish *adiós*; but for everyday partings it’s *arrivederci*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “arrivederci” — *ar-ree-veh-DER-chee*
- arrivederci / au revoir / auf Wiedersehen — all “until we see again”
- “vedere” then English “video, vision” — the *see* root

Before you move on

What does *arrivederci* literally promise? (“Until we see each other again.”) What French and German goodbyes share that exact idea? (*au revoir*, *auf Wiedersehen*.) Which heavier Italian goodbye means “to God,” like Spanish *adiós*? (*addio*.) Next: “see you tomorrow” — **a domani**.

4.2 a domani — “see you tomorrow”

The “until re-seeing” pattern gives you a whole family of goodbyes: just name **when**. First: **a domani**, “to tomorrow.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **a domani** = *ah doh-MAH-nee*: clean open vowels, stress the *-ma-*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **a** = “to / until” (the same *a* from *arrivederci*).
- **domani** = “tomorrow,” from Latin **dē māne**, “*from the morning*.”

That word **māne** (“morning”) is quietly shared across the Romance family, and you may have already met its Spanish child:

- Italian **domani** (“tomorrow”) ← *dē māne*.
- Spanish **mañana** ← (*hōra*) *māneāna* — which means **both** “morning” *and* “tomorrow,” because tomorrow *is* “the coming morning.”

So a *domani* literally says “**until the morning [to come]**.” You part by pointing at daybreak.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “a domani” — *ah doh-MAH-nee*
- Italian *domani* and Spanish *mañana* — both from *māne*, “morning”

Before you move on

What does *domani* come from, and what does it literally mean? (*Dē māne* — “from the morning.”) Which Spanish word shares that *māne* root? (*Mañana* — morning *and* tomorrow.) Next: “see you soon” — **a presto**.

4.3 a presto — “see you soon”

Same frame, new “when”: **a presto**, “to soon.” And *presto* is a word English already borrowed whole — from stage magic and music.

Sounds you'll need

- **a presto** = *ah PREH-stoh*: clean *st*, crisp open *e*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **a** = “to / until.”
- **presto** = “soon, quickly,” from Latin **praestō**, “*at hand, ready, present*” (*prae-* “before” + *stō/stāre* “stand” — literally “standing before you,” ready to hand).

English took **presto** straight from Italian:

- in **music**, *presto* means “fast.”
- in stage magic, “*presto!*” means “quick — and there it is!”
- it shares that *stō* (“stand”) root with *stare* from your how-are-you chapter, and with English **station**, **stable**, **status**.

So *a presto* is “**until [it is] soon / at hand**” — see you before long.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “a presto” — *ah PREH-stoh*
- “presto” as music (“fast”) and magic (“presto!”) — same word

Before you move on

What does *presto* mean, and where has English borrowed it? (“Soon / quickly” — in music and magic.) What “stand” root does it share with *stare*? (Latin *stō/stāre*.) Next: “see you later” — **a più tardi**.

4.4 a più tardi — “see you later”

The last “when” in the set: **a più tardi**, “to later” — literally “to *more late*.” Two small words, both alive in English.

Sounds you'll need

- **piu-glide** — **più** = *pyoo*, one gliding syllable (the accent marks the stress).
- **a più tardi** = *ah pyoo TAR-dee*, tapped *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **a** = “to / until.”
- **più** = “more,” from Latin **plūs** — the very word English took for **plus**, and the root of **plural**, **surplus**.
- **tardi** = “late,” from Latin **tardus**, “*slow, late*” → English **tardy**, **re-tard** (“to slow down”), **tardy** slip.

Together, *più tardi* = “**more late**” = “later.” So *a più tardi* is “until [it’s] more-late” — see you later on. (Italian builds “later” as *more late*, just as English does with the comparative *-er*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “a più tardi” — *ah pyoo TAR-dee*
- “più” ~ English *plus*; “tardi” ~ English *tardy* — both borrowed
- the four goodbyes — *arrivederci* / *a domani* / *a presto* / *a più tardi*

Before you move on

What do *più* and *tardi* mean, and their English cousins? (*Più* = “more” ~ *plus*; *tardi* = “late” ~ *tardy*.) So *a più tardi* literally says? (“To more-late” → see you later.) Next: put the farewells together.

4.5 Practice — saying goodbye in Italian

No new words. You can now open a conversation, ask how someone is, and **close** it. Run the goodbyes until the right one comes automatically.

You'll want to know: the closings**Neutral / polite** (anyone):— È stato un piacere. **Arrivederci!** — **Arrivederci!****With a “when”** — pick the promise that fits:

— **A domani!** (see you tomorrow) — **A presto!** (see you soon)
 — **A più tardi!** (see you later — same day)

Casual (a friend): the *ciao* you learned in Chapter 1 doubles as “bye”— **Ciao, a presto!****What you've built this chapter**

- **arrivederci** — goodbye (“until we re-see each other”; the *au revoir* / *auf Wiedersehen* family). Heavier, final variant: **addio** (“to God,” twin of *adiós*).
- **a domani** — see you tomorrow (*domani* ← *dē māne*, “morning”; kin of Spanish *mañana*).
- **a presto** — see you soon (*presto* ← *praestō*, “at hand” — the English music/magic word).
- **a più tardi** — see you later (*più* ~ plus, *tardi* ~ tardy).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- greet, ask, and close — “Ciao! Come stai? ... A domani!”
- choose the right goodbye — leaving till tomorrow / in an hour / for good
- arrivederci / au revoir / auf Wiedersehen — the “re-seeing” trio

Twice through: Open and close a whole tiny exchange without stopping.

Before you move on

Which goodbye means “until we see each other again”? (*Arrivederci.*)
Which says “to the morning”? (*A domani.*) Which Italian goodbye
matches Spanish *adiós* — “to God”? (*Addio.*) You can now run an
Italian conversation start to finish.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

5.1 parlare — “to speak,” the model -are verb

Until now you’ve assembled fixed phrases. **parlare** (“to speak”) is your first real **verb** and the model for Italian’s largest **-are** family. Learn this pattern and you drive thousands.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — a single tapped *r*: **parlare** = *par-LA-reh*.
- **vowel-a-open** — clean open *ah* vowels.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

parlare comes from Late Latin **parabolāre**, “to tell parables, to discourse” — from **parabola**, “a comparison, a speech” (Greek *parabolē*). So to *speak* is, at root, to *tell parables*. The English family:

- **parable**, **parole** (a word of honour), **palaver**, **parley**, **parliament** (a *talking*-place).

And a lovely cross-link: **Italian *parlare*** and **French *parler*** are the **same word** — both from *parabolāre*. **Spanish went a different way**: its “to speak,” *hablar*, is from *fabulārī* (“to chat,” ← *fābula* → fable). So Italy and France “tell parables”; Spain “tells fables.”

Grammar Lens: the -are present tense (and pro-drop)

Drop **-are** to get *parl-*, then add the endings:

person	ending	<i>parlare</i> →
(io)	-o	parlo (I speak)
(tu)	-i	parli (you speak)
(lui/lei)	-a	parla (he/she speaks)
(noi)	-iamo	parliamo
(voi)	-ate	parlate
(loro)	-ano	parlano

Like Spanish (*hablo/hablas*), **Italian drops the subject pronoun** — *parlo* already says “I,” so you don’t need *io*. This closes a neat circle you’ve been building:

- **Drop the pronoun:** Spanish (*hablo*), **Italian (*parlo*)** — endings are distinct.
- **Keep the pronoun:** French (*je parle* — endings silent), German (*ich wohne* — grammar needs a subject).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “parlare” — *par-LA-reh*
- “parlo, parli, parla” — no *io* needed
- parlare / parler (same *parabolāre*) vs Spanish *hablar* (*fabulārī*)

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *parlare*, and which French verb is its twin? (*parabolāre* — French *parler*.) Which Romance “speak” verb is from a *different* root, and which? (Spanish *hablar* ← *fabulārī*.) Does Italian keep or drop *io*, and why? (Drops it — the endings are distinct.) Next: **abitare**, “to live.”

5.2 abitare — “to live,” about *having a place*

A second **-are** verb — snap it into the endings you just learned. **abitare** (“to live, to dwell”) lets you say *where* you live — and it’s the twin of French *habiter*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **abitare** = *a-bee-TA-reh* (Italian dropped the Latin *h*-, but the spelling and sense stayed). Clean open vowels, tapped *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

abitare comes from Latin **habitāre**, “to dwell, to keep having [a place]” — the **frequentative** of **habēre**, “to have.” To *dwell* is to *keep having* your place. The English family:

- **habitat** — where a creature dwells; **inhabit**, **inhabitant**, **habitation**.
- via *habēre* (“have”): **habit** (what you keep having), **able**, **ability**.

French kept the *h* in spelling (*habiter*); Italian dropped it (*abitare*) — same Latin verb, same meaning. Now you can answer a *dove* (“where”) question:

Abito a Roma. — “I live in Rome.” (No *io* — pro-drop.)

Grammar Lens: same -are template

| (io) abito · (tu) abiti · (lui/lei) abita | (-o / -i / -a) |
| abitiamo · abitate · abitano | |

Identical to *parlare* — nothing new. That’s the whole point of a regular pattern.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “abitare” — *a-bee-TA-reh*
- “abito, abiti, abita” — same endings as *parlo/parli/parla*

- “Abito a Roma”; and “abitare” ↔ English *habitat*

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *abitare* from, and what does it literally involve? (*habitāre* — “keep having a place,” ← *habēre*, “to have.”) English cousins? (Habitat, inhabit.) Say “I live in Rome.” (*Abito a Roma.*) Next: **lavorare**, “to work.”

5.3 **lavorare** — “to work,” the honest kind

A third **-are** verb — and a satisfying twist. Where Spanish and French built their word for “work” out of **torture**, **Italian took a different road entirely**: *lavorare*, from plain Latin “to labour.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **lavorare** = *la-vo-RA-reh*: clean vowels, tapped *r*. (The *v* is a real *v*, unlike Spanish.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lavorare comes from Latin **labōrāre**, “to labour, to work, to strive” — from **labor**, “toil, effort.” No torture device here; just honest labour. The English family is large and dignified:

- **labor** / **labour**, **laborious**, **laboratory** (a *working-place*).
- **elaborate** (“worked out”), **collaborate** (“labour together”).

Here’s the cross-language payoff — the same idea, **two very different roots**:

language	“to work”	from	literal picture
Italian	<i>lavorare</i>	<i>labōrāre</i>	labour, effort
Spanish	<i>trabajar</i>	<i>tripalium</i>	a torture rack
French	<i>travailler</i>	<i>tripalium</i>	a torture rack

Spain and France remember work as *torture* (→ *travail/travel*); Italy remembers it as *labour*. A single glance at three verbs, and you see two Roman attitudes to a day’s work.

Grammar Lens: same -are template

| (io) lavoro · (tu) lavori · (lui/lei) lavora | (-o / -i / -a) |

Lavoro a Milano. — “I work in Milan.”**Your turn**

Say these aloud:

- “lavorare” — *la-vo-RA-reh*
- “lavoro, lavori, lavora”
- Italian *lavorare* (labour) vs Spanish *trabajar* / French *travailler* (torture)

Before you move on

What Latin word is *lavorare* from, and its English cousins? (*labōrāre* — labor, laboratory, elaborate.) How does its root differ from Spanish *trabajar* and French *travailler*? (Those are from *tripalium*, “torture”; Italian is from *labor*, “toil.”) Say “I work in Milan.” (*Lavoro a Milano.*) Next: your first sentence — **Parlo italiano.**

5.4 Parlo italiano — your first real sentence

The moment it pays off: you take a **verb** you conjugated and a **noun**, and build a sentence no one handed you — *Parlo italiano*, “I speak Italian.” (Italian *parlo* covers both “I speak” and “I am speaking.”)

You’ll want to know: italiano

italiano = “Italian,” from **Italia** — the ancient name of the peninsula itself. Its own origin is delightfully humble: many scholars trace *Italia* to Oscan **víteliú**, “land of calves / young cattle” (kin to Latin *vitulus*, “calf,” and perhaps English *veal*). So *Italia* may literally have meant “**Calf-land.**” Say it *ee-ta-LYA-no*.

You'll want to know: the assembled sentence

Snap two things you own together:

Parlo (I speak, from *parlare*) + **italiano** (Italian) = **Parlo italiano.**

A complete, grammatical Italian sentence. Notice what's *not* there:

- **No *io*.** Italian drops it (like Spanish *hablo español*) — the *-o* of *parlo* already says “I”. *Io parlo italiano* is fine for emphasis only.
- **No article** on the language: *parlo italiano*.

This closes the **pronoun-rule circle** you've watched across five languages:

	pronoun	why
Spanish / Italian	dropped	<i>hablo/parlo</i> : distinct endings
French <i>je parle</i>	kept	endings are silent
German <i>ich lerne</i>	kept	grammar needs an overt subject

Swap the pieces: **Abito a Roma.** · **Lavoro a Milano.** · **Parli italiano?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Parlo italiano” — *PAR-lo ee-ta-LYA-no*
- drop the *io* — Italian doesn't need it (like Spanish, unlike French)
- “italiano” ← *Italia*, maybe “calf-land” — a humble, formerly name

Before you move on

Where does *italiano* come from, and what might *Italia* have meant? (*Italia*; perhaps “land of calves.”) In *Parlo italiano*, why no *io* and no article? (The *-o* ending is “I”; languages take no article.) Which two of the five languages *drop* the pronoun? (Spanish and Italian.) Next: practice.

5.5 Practice — making sentences with -are verbs

For the first time you're **building** Italian sentences from a pattern, not reciting phrases. Drill the three verbs until the endings are automatic — and remember, Italian drops the *io*.

Grammar Lens: conjugate on command

Run each through *io* / *tu* / *lui-lei* (pronoun dropped in speech):

- **parlare**: parlo · parli · parla
- **abitare**: abito · abiti · abita
- **lavorare**: lavoro · lavori · lavora

Same endings every time (**-o** / **-i** / **-a**), and no pronoun needed.

Grammar Lens: say something real

— **Parli** italiano? — Sì, **parlo** un po'. E tu? — Anch'io.
Dove abiti? — **Abito** a Roma, e **lavoro** a Milano. —
 Grazie! — Prego.

What you've built this chapter

- **the regular -are present tense** — drop *-are*, add *-o/-i/-a/-iamo/-ate/-ano*; the pronoun is **dropped** (like Spanish).
- **parlare** (← *parabolāre* → parable; = French *parler*, vs Spanish *hablar*), **abitare** (← *habitāre* → habitat; twin of *habiter*), **lavorare** (← *labōrāre* → labor/laboratory — the “labour” road, not Spanish/French “torture”).
- **Parlo italiano** — first self-assembled sentence (*italiano* ← *Italia*, perhaps “calf-land”).
- **The pronoun circle across 5 languages**: ES *hablo* + IT *parlo* drop; FR *je parle* (silent endings) + DE *ich lerne* (grammar) keep.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three verbs, io/tu/lui — no pronoun spoken
- answer about yourself — what you speak, where you live, where you work
- chain it — “Ciao! Parlo italiano. Parli italiano? ... Arrivederci!”

Twice through: “Parli italiano? — Sì, parlo un po’.”

Before you move on

What are the three singular *-are* endings? (*-o / -i / -a.*) Give the “I” forms of the three verbs. (*Parlo, abito, lavoro.*) Which languages drop the subject pronoun, and which keep it, and why? (Drop: ES/IT — distinct endings; keep: FR — silent endings, DE — grammar.) Italian now moves in real sentences.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Ten

6.1 uno, due, tre, quattro, cinque — counting to five

Of all the Romance sisters, **Italian kept the numbers closest to Latin** — it stayed in Italy, next to Rome, and wore the words down the least. Beside each you'll see the Spanish and French cousins for contrast.

Sounds you'll need

- **double-tt** — **quattro**: hold the double *t* audibly, *KWAT-tro* (Italian really doubles its consonants).
- **c-before-i** — **cinque** = *CHEEN-kweh*: *c* before *i/e* is a “ch” sound, but the *-que* stays a hard *kw*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	Spanish / French	English cousins
uno (1)	<i>ūnus</i>	<i>uno</i> / <i>un</i>	unit, union, unique (and <i>a/an, one</i>)
due (2)	<i>duo</i>	<i>dos</i> / <i>deux</i>	duo, dual, duet, double
tre (3)	<i>trēs</i>	<i>tres</i> / <i>trois</i>	trio, triple, triangle
quattro (4)	<i>quattuor</i>	<i>cuatro</i> / <i>quatre</i>	quart, quarter, quatrain
cinque (5)	<i>quīnque</i>	<i>cinco</i> / <i>cing</i>	quintet, quintessence

Notice **cinque** — Italian kept Latin *quīnque* almost whole (*-que* and all), while Spanish softened it to *cinco* and French clipped it to *cing*. And **quattro** is why a musical foursome is a *quartet* and four singers make a *quattro*-anything. Italian is the sister who changed her Latin the least.

Grammar Lens: *uno* → *un* / *uno* / *una*

uno is also “a/an,” and it flexes by gender and the following sound: **un** (before most masc. nouns), **uno** (before tricky masc. clusters like *s+consonant* or *z-*), **una** (fem.). *un caffè* “a/one coffee,” *una birra* “a/one beer.” The others (*due, tre...*) don’t change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “uno, due, tre, quattro, cinque” — count up
- each with its English cousin — “due/duo, tre/trio, quattro/quart, cinque/quintet”
- “un caffè, una birra” — *uno* → *un/una* before a noun

Before you move on

Give 1–5 in Italian. (*Uno, due, tre, quattro, cinque.*) Which Italian number kept Latin *quīnque* most intact, versus Spanish and French? (*cinque*, vs *cinco* / *cing.*) What does *un/una* mean besides “one”? (“A/an.”) Next: **6–10**, and the months hidden inside them.

6.2 sei, sette, otto, nove, dieci — and the calendar’s secret

The rest of the count hides a calendar fact: **settembre–dicembre are Latin for 7, 8, 9, 10.** Italian even keeps the old Latin double consonants that show it.

Sounds you’ll need

- double-**tt** — **sette** = *SET-teh*, **otto** = *OT-toh*: lean on the doubled *t*, a giveaway that Latin’s *-pt-* and *-ct-* both collapsed into *-tt-*.
- **c-before-i** — **dieci** = *DYE-chee* (the *c* before *i* → “ch”).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	Spanish twin	English cousins
sei (6)	<i>sex</i>	<i>seis</i>	sextet , sextant
sette (7)	<i>septem</i>	<i>siete</i>	settembre (the 7 th month!), septet
otto (8)	<i>octō</i>	<i>ocho</i>	ottobre (8 th), octave , octopus
nove (9)	<i>novem</i>	<i>nueve</i>	novembre (9 th), novena
dieci (10)	<i>decem</i>	<i>diez</i>	dicembre (10 th), decimal , decade

Watch the doubled consonants do historical work: Latin *septem* had a *-pt-* that Italian smoothed to *-tt-* → **sette**; Latin *octō* had a *-ct-* that likewise became *-tt-* → **otto**. Italian didn't drop those clusters (as French did in *huit*) — it **assimilated** them into twins. So *otto* and *ottobre* still show the 8 side by side.

Grammar Lens: why the months are “off by two”

Settembre means “7th,” but it's the **9th** month. The old **Roman year began in March**, so *September* really was the seventh; later *luglio* and *agosto* (July and August, for Julius and Augustus) pushed the counting months down two slots. The Latin numbers stuck to the labels. Every *dicembre*, you say Roman “**ten**” — just as in Spanish *diciembre* and French *décembre*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sei, sette, otto, nove, dieci” — finish the count
- “sette/settembre, otto/ottobre, nove/novembre, dieci/dicembre”

- “octō → otto” — the *-ct-* becoming a doubled *-tt-*

Before you move on

Give 6–10 in Italian. (*Sei, sette, otto, nove, dieci.*) What happened to Latin’s *-ct-* in *octō* → *otto*? (It assimilated to a doubled *-tt-*.) Why is *dicembre* Latin for “ten”? (The Roman year began in March.) Next chapter builds on this toward time and days.

Chapter 7

Days of the Week

7.1 lunedì to venerdì — the planet-week, Italian-style

Italy sat at the centre of the Roman world, so its weekday names are the **planet-week** almost undisturbed — the same map of the sky French uses. The tell is the little accented **-dì** at the end of each.

Sounds you'll need

- **final-stress-i** — the **-dì** carries a **written accent** and the **stress**: *lu-ne-DÌ*, *mar-te-DÌ*. That accent marks “day” (*diēs*) and where your voice lands.
- **c-before-i** — **mercoledì** = *mer-co-le-DÌ* (hard *c* here, before *o*).

Grammar Lens: [planet] + dì

dì is Latin **diēs**, “day” — the same *-di* you’d hear in French *lundi*. Before it sits a **planet-god**:

Italian	← Latin	planet	Spanish twin	French twin
lunedì	<i>lūnae diēs</i>	Moon	<i>lunes</i>	<i>lundi</i>
martedì	<i>Martis diēs</i>	Mars	<i>martes</i>	<i>mardi</i>
mercoledì	<i>Mercurii diēs</i>	Mercury	<i>miércoles</i>	<i>mercredi</i>
giovedì	<i>Jovis diēs</i>	Jupiter (<i>Giove</i>)	<i>jueves</i>	<i>jeudi</i>
venerdì	<i>Veneris diēs</i>	Venus (<i>Venere</i>)	<i>viernes</i>	<i>vendredi</i>

Line up the three sisters — *lunedì* / *lunes* / *lundi* — and you’re looking at one Roman word, *lūnae diēs*, worn three ways. Italian and French keep the day-word at the **end** (*lune-dì*, *lun-dì*); Spanish clipped it off entirely (*lunes*). And *giovedì* wears **Giove**, the Italian name of Jupiter — the same king-god English honours as Thor in *Thursday*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lunedì, martedì, mercoledì, giovedì, venerdì” — mind the final stress
- the three-sister line — “lunedì / lunes / lundi”, “martedì / martes / mardi”
- “-dì = diēs = day” — the accented tail

Before you move on

What is the accented *-dì*, and from what Latin word? (“Day,” ← *diēs*.) Which planet is *giovedì*? (Jupiter — *Giove*.) How do Italian/French treat the day-word versus Spanish? (IT/FR keep it at the end, *-dì/-dì*; Spanish dropped it, *lunes*.) Next: the **weekend** — *sabato* and *domenica*.

7.2 sabato and domenica — the religious weekend

The five weekdays were planets; the two weekend days are **faith**. Here the accented *-dì* disappears, because these names never

came from *diēs* + a god — they came from the Sabbath and the Lord.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	meaning	Spanish twin
sabato	<i>Sabbatum</i> ← Hebrew <i>shabbāt</i>	the “ Sabbath ,” the day of rest	<i>sábado</i>
domenica	(<i>diēs</i>) <i>Dominica</i> ← <i>Dominus</i>	“the Lord’s day”	<i>domingo</i>

- **sabato** is the **Sabbath** — Latin *Sabbatum* straight from Hebrew *shabbāt*, “to cease, to rest.” Where English kept the planet (**Saturday** = Saturn), Italian, Spanish, and French all took the Jewish rest-day instead (*sabato* / *sábado* / *samedi*).
- **domenica** is “the **Lord’s** day,” *diēs Dominica*, from *Dominus* “lord, master” (→ English *dominion*, *dominate*, *dame*, *don*). Christianity renamed the old “Sun’s day”: English still says **Sunday**, but Italian and Spanish point to the Lord (*domenica* / *domingo*). Note *domenica* is **feminine** (*la domenica*) — *diēs* went feminine here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full week — “lunedì ... venerdì, sabato, domenica”
- “sabato = Sabbath, domenica = the Lord’s day” — faith, not planets
- the sisters — “sabato / sábado”, “domenica / domingo”

Before you move on

Give all seven Italian days. (*Lunedì ... domenica*.) Where does *sabato* come from? (The **Sabbath**, *Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt*.) What does *domenica* mean, and its Spanish twin? (“The **Lord’s** day”; *domingo*.) Next chapter builds on this toward telling the time.

Chapter 8

Telling Time

8.1 ora — the hour, told with “le”

Italian’s word for “hour” is **ora**, straight from Latin **hōra** (which Rome took from Greek *hōrā*, “a time of day”). Telling the time in Italian has one neat twist: you use the **feminine article** and let *ore* (“hours”) stay implied.

Sounds you’ll need

- open-o — **ora** = *OH-ra*, open *o*, single tapped *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ora ← Latin **hōra** ← Greek **hōrā**. It’s the closest of the sisters to the Latin: French wore it to *heure*, but Italian barely touched it — *hōra* → *ora* (Italian dropped the silent Latin *h*- in spelling, too). Same word as English *hour*, and as German’s borrowed *Uhr*.

Grammar Lens: “è l’una” but “sono le due”

Here’s the twist. Italian tells the time with the **feminine article** (because *ora/ore* is feminine), and the verb agrees with the number:

È l’una. — “It is one o’clock.” (singular: *è* “it is” + *l’una* = “the one [hour]”) **Sono le due.** — “It is two o’clock.” (plural: *sono* “they are” + *le due* = “the two [hours]”) **Sono le dieci.** — “It is ten o’clock.”

Literally “**they are** the two [hours]” — Italian counts the hours as feminine things and drops the word *ore* entirely; the article **le** carries it.

Only **one o'clock** is singular (*è l'una*); from two on, it's *sono le ...*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ora” — *OH-ra*
- “è l'una ... sono le due, sono le tre, sono le quattro”
- “ora / heure / Uhr / hour” — all Latin *hōra*

Before you move on

What word is *ora* from, and its sisters? (Latin *hōra* ← Greek *hōrā*; French *heure*, German *Uhr*, English *hour*.) Why “*sono le due*” but “*è l'una*”? (Plural hours take *sono le ...*; one o'clock is singular *è l'una*.) What word does the *le* stand in for? (*ore*, “hours” — feminine.) Next: **mezzogiorno** and **mezzanotte** — noon and midnight.

8.2 mezzogiorno and mezzanotte — Italy's noon and midnight

The two unnumbered hours. **mezzogiorno** (noon) and **mezzanotte** (midnight) are, like their French cousins, the **middle** of the day and the night — built from *mezzo* “half/middle” plus *giorno* “day” and *notte* “night.”

Sounds you'll need

- **double-zz** — **mezzo** = *MED-dzo*, the doubled *zz* a hard “ts/dz” — lean on it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The front piece is **mezzo/mezza**, “half, middle,” from Latin **medius** (cousin of English *medium*, *mid*, and of French *mi-* in *midi*):

Italian	=	← Latin	literally
mezzogiorno	<i>mezzo</i> + <i>giorno</i>	<i>medius</i> + <i>diurnum</i>	“ mid-day ” (noon)
mezzanotte	<i>mezza</i> + <i>notte</i>	<i>media</i> + <i>noctem</i>	“ mid-night ” (midnight)

- **mezzogiorno** = “mid-day.” *giorno* (“day”) is from Latin *diurnum* (“of the day”) — the same root as English *journal* and *journey* (a day’s travel). So noon is “the middle of the day-span.”
- **mezzanotte** = “mid-night.” *notte* (“night”) ← *noctem*, twin of English *night* and French *nuit*. *mezza* is the **feminine** “half” (agreeing with the feminine *notte*), where *mezzo* is masculine (with *giorno*) — the article system you just met, again.

To use them, they *are* the hour:

È mezzogiorno. — “It is noon.” **È mezzanotte.** — “It is midnight.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mezzogiorno” (noon), “mezzanotte” (midnight)
- break them — “mezzo (middle) + giorno (day)”, “mezza + notte (night)”
- “È mezzogiorno. È mezzanotte.” — singular *è*, no number

Before you move on

What do *mezzogiorno* and *mezzanotte* literally mean? (“Mid-day” and “mid-night.”) What is *mezzo/mezza* from, and its French cousin? (Latin *medius*; French *mi-* in *midi/minuit*.) Why *mezzanotte* but *mezzogiorno*? (*mezza* is feminine for *notte*, *mezzo* masculine for *giorno*.) Next chapter builds on this toward months and family.

Chapter 9

Months and Seasons

9.1 i mesi — Rome's own months

Sitting next to Rome, Italian kept the month names **closest to Latin** of all the sisters — the same procession of gods and Caesars, barely worn. And two things you know pay off: *marzo* is the war-god of *martedì*, and *settembre–dicembre* are the Latin numbers 7–10.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	who / what	Spanish twin
gennaio	<i>Januarius</i>	Janus , god of beginnings	<i>enero</i>
febbraio	<i>Februarius</i>	the <i>Februa</i> purification	<i>febrero</i>
marzo	<i>Martius</i>	Mars — the god of martedì!	<i>marzo</i>
aprile	<i>Aprilis</i>	<i>aperire</i> “to open”	<i>abril</i>
maggio	<i>Maius</i>	Maia , growth-goddess	<i>mayo</i>
giugno	<i>Junius</i>	Juno , queen of gods	<i>junio</i>
luglio	<i>Julius</i>	Julius Caesar	<i>julio</i>
agosto	<i>Augustus</i>	emperor Augustus	<i>agosto</i>
settembre	<i>september</i>	“ 7th ” (<i>septem</i>)	<i>septiembre</i>
ottobre	<i>october</i>	“ 8th ” (<i>octo</i>)	<i>octubre</i>
novembre	<i>november</i>	“ 9th ” (<i>novem</i>)	<i>noviembre</i>
dicembre	<i>december</i>	“ 10th ” (<i>decem</i>)	<i>diciembre</i>

The Italian tells: *gennaio* kept the *-aio* of *Januarius*, and *settembre/ottobre* keep the doubled/assimilated look (*ottobre*, like *otto*). And two payoffs land:

- **marzo = Mars = martedì.** The month and Tuesday honour the *same* war-god — *Martius* and *Martedì*. One unlocks the other.
- **settembre...dicembre = 7...10.** Still the Latin numbers, because the Roman year began in **March**; then *luglio* (Julius) and *agosto* (Augustus) were inserted and shifted the count.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “gennaio, febbraio, marzo ... novembre, dicembre”

- “marzo / martedì — both Mars”
- “settembre = 7, dicembre = 10”

Before you move on

Which god links *marzo* and *martedì*? (**Mars**.) Why is *dicembre* Latin for “ten”? (The Roman year began in March.) Which two months honour real **people**? (*Luglio* — Julius; *agosto* — Augustus.) Next: the **stagioni**, the seasons.

9.2 le stagioni — the four seasons

The word for “season,” **stagione**, is itself a small lesson: it’s Latin **statiō**, a “standing” — a fixed *station* of the year (cousin of English *station*, *stage*). And the loveliest of the four, **primavera**, means the “**first green**.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	literally
la primavera (spring)	<i>prīma vēra</i>	“ first spring / first green ” (<i>prima</i> “first” + <i>vera</i> ← <i>ver</i> “spring”)
l’estate (summer)	<i>aestas / aestātem</i>	“the heat, the hot season”
l’autunno (autumn)	<i>autumnus</i>	“autumn” (twin of English <i>autumn</i>)
l’inverno (winter)	<i>hibernum</i>	“the wintry season” (cousin of <i>hibernate</i>)

- **primavera** = *prima* + *vera*: the “first spring.” Latin *vēr* was the word for spring; Italian (and Spanish, and Portuguese) built “prima-vera,” the year’s *first* season — the same idea French once had in *primevère*.
- **estate** ← *aestas*, “heat.” **autunno** ← *autumnus*, the same word English borrowed. **inverno** ← *hibernum* “wintry” — English **hibernate** is “to spend the *inverno*.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la primavera, l’estate, l’autunno, l’inverno”
- “primavera = prima + vera (first green)”; “inverno ~ hibernate”
- “stagione ← statio — a ‘standing’ of the year, like station”

Before you move on

Name the four Italian seasons. (*Primavera, estate, autunno, inverno.*)
What does *primavera* literally mean? (“**First spring / first green.**”)
What Latin word is *stagione* from, and its English cousin? (*Statio* “a standing”; *station.*) Next chapter builds on this toward family and food.

Chapter 10

Family

10.1 il padre, la madre — closest to Latin

Italian, as ever, stays nearest to Rome. Its **padre** (“father”) and **madre** (“mother”) barely moved from Latin **pater** and **māter** — Latin just softened the *-t-* to *-d-*. If you know the Latin, you nearly know the Italian.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **il padre** (“father”) ← Latin **pater** (*-t-* → *-d-*).
- **la madre** (“mother”) ← Latin **māter** (*-t-* → *-d-*).

Articles: *il* padre (masculine), *la* madre (feminine).

English already borrowed one of these whole: a **padre** is what English (and Spanish-influenced) speakers call a priest or military chaplain — *padre* itself, untouched.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian “parents” is **i genitori** — not from *parens* but from Latin **genitor**, “the **begetter**,” from *gignere* “to beget/bring forth.” That root *gen-* “give birth to” is everywhere in English: **genital**, **progenitor**, **genesis**, **generate**, **genus**, **gene**. So *i genitori* are literally “the begetters.” (Beware the **false friend**: Italian *parenti* means **relatives** in general, *not* “parents”!)

The Latin-through-English adjectives still come from *pater/māter*: **paternal** and **maternal** — the same roots as French *père/mère* and, by Grimm’s law, English *father/mother*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “il padre, la madre” — soft *-d-* where Latin had *-t-*
- “i genitori = the parents; *genitor* = begetter → genesis, gene”
- the false-friend warning — “*parenti* = relatives, NOT parents”

Before you move on

Give “father” and “mother” with articles. (**il padre, la madre.**) What single sound did Latin *pater/māter* soften to? (The *-t-* became **-d-**.) What does **genitori** literally mean, and name an English cousin. (“The **begetters**”; genesis/gene/progenitor.) What does the false friend *parenti* mean? (**Relatives**, not parents.) Next: **fratello** and **sorella**.

10.2 il fratello, la sorella — brother and sister, with a little-ending

Here Italian does something charming. Where French kept *frère* and *sœur* bare, Italian rebuilt “brother” and “sister” with its beloved **diminutive** endings — literally “**little brother**” and “**little sister**” — and those forms became the everyday words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **il fratello** (“brother”) ← Latin **frāter** + the diminutive **-ellus** → *fraterellus* → *fratello*, once “little brother.”
- **la sorella** (“sister”) ← Latin **soror** + the diminutive **-ella** → *sorella*, once “little sister.”

The root still shows: **frat-** and **soror-**, the same roots English turns into **fraternal**, **fraternity**, **friar** and **sorority**, **sororal**. Italian just wrapped them in the affectionate *-ello/-ella* that also gives *fratello*’s cousins across the language (*-ello* on *poverello* “poor little one,” *-ella* on countless names).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all four — “il padre, la madre, il fratello, la sorella”
- the build — “*frater* + *-ello* → fratello, ‘little brother’”
- “fratello → fraternal; sorella → sorority”

Before you move on

Give “brother” and “sister” with articles. (**il fratello, la sorella.**) What did Italian **add** to Latin *frāter/soror* to make them? (A **diminutive** ending, *-ello* / *-ella* — “little brother/sister.”) Name an English cousin of each root. (*frat-* → fraternal/friar; *soror-* → sorority.) Next chapter: sentences about the family.

Chapter 11

Bread, Water, and Wine

11.1 il pane — bread, and its companions

il pane (“bread”) — and, true to form, Italian keeps it **closest to Latin**: *pānis* → *pane*, barely touched. Its root carries the same warm story as the French *pain*: a **companion** is one you **share bread** with.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **il pane** (“bread”) ← Latin **pānis** — masculine, *il* pane; the plural is *i pani*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **companion / company** ← *com-* (“with”) + *pānis* — “one you **break bread with**.”
- **pantry, pannier** (a bread-basket).
- And a purely Italian gem: **companatico** — the word for “**whatever you eat with bread**” (cheese, salami, anything on it). The bread is the given; the *companatico* is what joins it — the same *com-* + *pānis* idea, alive in one Italian word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “il pane” — open *e*; plural “i pani”
- “pane → companion, companatico” — bread and what joins it

Before you move on

Give “bread” with its article. (**il pane.**) What Latin word, and how much did Italian change it? (*pānis* — barely: *pānis* → *pane.*) What does *companatico* mean, and how does it use the bread-root? (“What you eat **with** bread” — *com-* “with” + *pānis.*) Next: **l’acqua** and **il vino.**

11.2 l’acqua, il vino — water and wine, close to the source

The Italian table’s two drinks — and a neat contrast with French. Where French dissolved Latin *aqua* into a bare **eau** (“oh”), Italian kept it almost **whole**: **acqua**, with the *aqua* still ringing in it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **l’acqua** (“water”) ← Latin **aqua**. Italian barely moved it — it even **doubles** the sound with **-cq-** (*AH-kwa*), holding onto the hard *qu* that French threw away. Set them side by side: Latin *aqua* → Italian **acqua** (kept) vs French **eau** (worn to a vowel). English borrowed the same loud original for **aquatic**, **aquarium**, **aqueduct**. Takes *l’* before the vowel.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **il vino** (“wine”) ← Latin **vīnum** — clean and close, like everything Italian. The same word travelled into English as **wine**, and gives **vine**, **vinegar**, **vintage**, **vineyard**, **vinyl**. Masculine: *il* vino.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “l’acqua, il vino” — *acqua* with the doubled *-cq-*
- the contrast — “Latin *aqua* → Italian **acqua** (kept), French **eau** (worn away)”

- “acqua $\leftrightarrow$ aquarium; vino $\rightarrow$ wine, vinegar”

Before you move on

Give “water” and “wine” with articles. (**l’acqua, il vino.**) How does Italian *acqua* differ from French *eau*, from the same *aqua*? (Italian **kept** it — even doubling *-cq-*; French wore it to a single vowel.) Name an English cousin of each. (*acqua* $\rightarrow$ aquatic/aquarium; *vino* $\rightarrow$ wine/vinegar.) Next chapter: asking for these at a table.

Chapter 12

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

12.1 undici → sedici — the ten you can still see

True to form, Italian keeps the teens **closest to Latin** — so close that the word for “ten” is still sitting in plain sight inside each one. Where French wore *decem* down to a bare **-ze**, Italian kept **-dici**.

Grammar Lens: six fusions

	Italian	← Latin	build
11	undici	<i>ūndecim</i>	un + dici
12	dodici	<i>duodecim</i>	do + dici
13	tredici	<i>trēdecim</i>	tre + dici
14	quattordici	<i>quattuordecim</i>	quattor + dici
15	quindici	<i>quīndecim</i>	quin + dici
16	sedici	<i>sēdecim</i>	se + dici

Every one is **digit + -dici**, and **-dici** is Latin **decem**, “ten” — the same ten you say as **dieci** (10). Compare the sisters and Italian’s clarity jumps out:

- Latin *sēdecim* → Italian **sedici** (ten still audible) · French **seize** (ten worn to a *-ze*) · Portuguese **dezesseis** (rebuilt from scratch).

The digits are your Chapter 6 numbers barely changed: *tre*→*tre-*, *quattro*→*quattor-*, *cinque*→*quin-*, *sei*→*se-*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “undici, dodici, tredici, quattordici, quindici, sedici”
- the ten inside — “-dici = *decem* = **dieci**”
- the three-sister line — “sedici / seize / dezesseis, one Latin word”

Before you move on

Count 11 to 16 in Italian. (*Undici, dodici, tredici, quattordici, quindici, sedici.*) What is the **-dici** in every one? (Latin **decem**, “ten” — the same as *dieci*.) Which order are they built in — digit first or ten first? (**Digit first**: *tre-dici* = “three-ten”.) Next: at **17**, Italian flips *both* its strategy **and** its direction.

12.2 diciassette → venti — the count turns around

Watch the language change direction. Through **sedici** (16), Italian put the **digit first** and the ten last. At **17**, it turns the whole thing around and puts the **ten first** — and it keeps the *-dici* right there so you can see it happen.

Grammar Lens: the reversal

	Italian	build	order
16	sedici	<i>se</i> + <i>dici</i>	six-ten
17	diciassette	<i>dici</i> + (<i>a</i>) + <i>sette</i>	ten-and-seven
18	diciotto	<i>dici</i> + <i>otto</i>	ten-eight
19	diciannove	<i>dici</i> + (<i>an</i>) + <i>nove</i>	ten-nine
20	venti	← <i>vīgintī</i>	—

Same building blocks — *dici* (“ten”) and your Chapter 6 digits — but from 17 the **ten leads**. The little linking sounds (*diciAssette*, *diciAN-nove*) are just Italian smoothing the joint, the doubling it loves.

What you’ve built: three different breaks

This “give up fusing, go transparent” seam happens in every Romance sister, but **not at the same place**:

language	fuses up to	goes transparent at
Portuguese	<i>quinze</i> (15)	16 — <i>dezesseis</i>
French	<i>seize</i> (16)	17 — <i>dix-sept</i>
Italian	<i>sedici</i> (16)	17 — <i>diciassette</i>

Three languages, one inherited Latin system, three different breaking points. (And German, you may recall, never breaks at all.)

venti (20) ← *vīgintī*, the same root as French *vingt* and English **vigesimal**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 16→20 — “sedici, diciassette, diciotto, diciannove, venti”
- the turn — “*se*-dici (six-ten) → *dici*-assette (ten-seven)”
- the whole run, undici to venti

Before you move on

What changes between *sedici* and *diciassette*? (The **order** — the **ten moves to the front**; digit-first becomes ten-first.) Where do the three Romance sisters break? (**Portuguese at 16, French and Italian at 17.**) What Latin word gives *venti*? (*vīgintī* — like French *vingt*, English *vigesimal*.) Next chapter: numbers in use.

Chapter 13

Colours

13.1 nero, bianco — one Roman, one Lombard

Italy's two most basic colours came from **two different peoples**. One is Rome's own word. The other arrived with the Germanic tribes who settled the peninsula after Rome fell.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nero (“black”) ← Latin *niger*. Straight inheritance, barely changed: *niger* → *nigrum* → *nero*. The same *niger* gives English *denigrate*, “to blacken.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's white was *albus*. Italian doesn't use it. Instead: **bianco**, from Germanic *blank* — “**shining, gleaming**” — most likely carried in by the **Lombards**, the Germanic people who ruled northern Italy for two centuries and left their name on **Lombardia**.

The same word became French *blanc* and Portuguese *branco*. Germanic lending **into** Romance is the reverse of the usual direction, and here the loan won so completely that Latin's own word was pushed out of the colour slot altogether.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

word	meaning	the white inside
alba	dawn	the sky turning white
albume	egg white	the white part
Albania , <i>Alpi</i>	(place names)	“the white ones”
<i>album</i> (Eng.)	album	a blank white tablet
Latin’s white is still here — just doing other jobs.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nero, bianco”
- “il vino bianco, il vino rosso” — Ch.11’s wine, coloured
- “il pane bianco” — Ch.11’s bread
- “l’alba” — and hear Latin’s forgotten white

Before you move on

Which colour is Rome’s own? (**Nero** ← *niger*.) Where does **bianco** come from? (**Germanic** *blank*, “shining” — likely via the **Lombards**.) Why is that surprising? (Latin normally lends **to** Germanic, not the reverse.) Where did *albus* survive? (In **alba**, “dawn,” and **albume** — no longer a colour.) Next: **rosso** and **blu**, and one more traveller.

13.2 rosso, blu — and the blue Italy plays in

One very old word, one more Germanic loan — and a third blue that came all the way from Persia by way of Arabic.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rosso ← Latin *russus* (“red”), from PIE *h₁rewd^h-*. That root is one of the oldest colour words we can reconstruct:

language	word
Italian	rosso
French	rouge (← <i>rubeus</i>)
English	red , <i>rust</i> , <i>ruby</i>
German	rot

Rosso and *red* are **cousins**, not borrowings — separated for millennia. Note the **double s**: hold it. *Roso* and *rosso* are different words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blu ← Germanic *blāo*, exactly like French *bleu*. Chapter pattern confirmed: **bianco** and **blu**, Italian’s white and blue, are both **Germanic imports**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian has a second blue, and it’s the famous one: **azzurro**, from Arabic *lāzaward* (“lapis lazuli”), itself from Persian *lāžward*. The initial *l-* was swallowed — heard as an article and dropped — leaving *azur/azzurro*. The same journey gave Spanish and Portuguese **azul**, French **azur**, and English **azure**.

Italy’s national teams are **gli Azzurri**, “the blue ones” — named, at the end of a very long chain, after a **blue stone mined in Afghanistan**.

What you’ve built: the colour paths

Italian	source
nero	Latin <i>niger</i>
bianco	Germanic <i>blank</i>
rosso	Latin <i>russus</i> (ancient PIE root)
blu	Germanic <i>blāo</i>
azzurro	Arabic <i>lāzaward</i>

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rosso, blu, azzurro”
- “il vino rosso” — Chapter 11’s wine

- the cousins — “rosso · red · rot · rouge”
- “gli Azzurri” — and think of the stone

Before you move on

Is *rosso* related to English *red* by borrowing or descent? (**Descent** — PIE *h₁rewd^h-*.) Which two Italian colours are Germanic loans? (**Bianco** and **blu**.) Where does **azzurro** come from? (**Arabic** *lāzaward*, “lapis lazuli” — via Persian; the *l-* was lost as if it were an article.) What are Italy’s teams called? (**Gli Azzurri**.) Next chapter: attaching these colours to the nouns you know.

Chapter 14

Having and Telling Your Age

14.1 avere — “to have”

Italian’s workhorse verb — and the home of the language’s **only silent letter**, which is there for a reason worth knowing.

You’ll want to know: the forms

ho	abbiamo
hai	avete
ha	hanno

Look at which forms carry an **h**: *ho*, *hai*, *ha*, *hanno*. And which don’t: *abbiamo*, *avete*.

Grammar Lens: why silent h survives

Italian threw the Latin **h** away almost completely — it is never pronounced, and *uomo* (← *homō*) and *erba* (← *herba*) simply dropped it. But in *avere* it stayed, because without it these words would collide:

with h	without h	meaning
ho — I have	o	“or”
hai — you have	ai	“to the”
ha — he/she has	a	“to”
hanno — they have	anno	“year”

Four minimal pairs, all extremely common. The **h** is silent, does nothing to the sound, and is kept **only so your eye can tell the words apart**. Spelling doing a job pronunciation can’t — hold onto *hanno* vs *anno*; it

comes back in the next lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

avere ← Latin *habēre*, the same source as French *avoir*. English took it as a whole family: **habit** (what you have regularly), **inhabit**, **exhibit** (“hold out”), **prohibit** (“hold back”).

Note *abbiamo* — the **bb** is the old *habē-* resurfacing in the *noi* form, while *ho* wore down to a single vowel.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ho, hai, ha, abbiamo, avete, hanno”
- “Ho un fratello” (“I have a brother”) — Ch. 10’s family
- the pair — “**hanno** they have · **anno** a year”
- “Abbiamo pane e vino” — Ch. 11’s food

Before you move on

Give the six forms. (*Ho, hai, ha, abbiamo, avete, hanno.*) Which carry an **h**? (*Ho, hai, ha, hanno.*) Is it pronounced? (**No** — never.) Then why is it there? (To keep them apart from **o, ai, a, anno** in **writing**.) What root is *avere* from? (Latin *habēre* → *habit/inhabit/exhibit*.) Next: *anno* takes centre stage.

14.2 ho venti anni — having your years

Italian states age with **avere**, not *essere*. And the silent **h** from last lesson stops being trivia here — it becomes the difference between two real sentences.

You’ll want to know: the phrase

Quanti anni hai? — “How many years do you **have**?” **Ho venti anni.** — “I **have** twenty years.”

Essere is wrong here. *Sono venti anni* does not mean “I am twenty.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

anno (“year”) ← Latin *annus* → English **annual**, **anniversary**, **annals**, *per annum*. Chapter 9’s months and seasons came from the same calendar vocabulary.

Note the **double n**: *a-nno*, held. Italian’s double consonants are real length, not decoration.

Grammar Lens: h earns its keep

Now put the last lesson to work:

sentence	meaning
Hanno venti anni.	“They have twenty years.”
anno	“ year ”

Hanno and *anno* sound **exactly the same**. Only the silent **h** tells them apart — and in a sentence about years, both words show up at once. That is precisely why Italian kept a letter it never pronounces.

Grammar Lens: who has and who is

language

Italian	<i>ho venti anni</i> — have
French	<i>j’ai vingt ans</i> — have
Spanish	<i>tengo veinte años</i> — have
Portuguese	<i>tenho vinte anos</i> — have
German	<i>ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt</i> — be
English	<i>I am twenty</i> — be

Romance has its years; Germanic is its years.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Quanti anni hai?”
- “Ho venti anni” — hold the **nn**
- your own age, using Ch. 12’s numbers
- the pair aloud — “**hanno ... anno**” — identical sound

Before you move on

Which verb does Italian use for age? (**Avere**, never *essere*.) What does *ho venti anni* literally say? (“I **have** twenty years.”) Where does *anno* come from? (Latin **annus** → *annual/anniversary*.) What separates *hanno* from *anno*? (**Only the silent h** — they sound identical.) Which two languages say “I **am**” instead? (**German and English**.)

Chapter 15

Two Italian Pasts

15.1 ho parlato — the past built from “have”

Italy’s everyday past tense, and you already own both halves: **avere** from last chapter, and Chapter 5’s verbs.

Grammar Lens: the compound-past recipe

avere (conjugated) + **past participle**

infinitive	ends in	participle
parlare	-are	parlato
lavorare	-are	lavorato
credere	-ere	creduto
dormire	-ire	dormito

ho parlato	I spoke / I have spoken
hai parlato	you spoke
ha parlato	he/she spoke
abbiamo parlato	we spoke
hanno parlato	they spoke

The silent **h** from last chapter is doing its job again: *ho parlato* on the page can’t be misread as *o parlato* (“or spoken”).

Note **parlato** keeps the *-t-* that French wore away: Italian *parlato*, French *parlé*, both from Latin *-ātum*. Italian is the more conservative sister — the same pattern as Chapter 11’s *acqua* against French *eau*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin could say:

habeō litterās scriptās — “I have letters **written**.”

Not a past tense: *avere* in its plain sense of **possessing**, with *scriptās* as an **adjective** agreeing with *litterās*. Over centuries “I possess a written thing” slid into simply “**I wrote**” — a possessive construction **hardened into a tense**.

The fossil survives. When the object comes **before** the verb, the participle still agrees with it, exactly as an adjective would:

Le ho viste. — “I saw them [f. pl].”

That *-e* is a Latin adjective ending, still agreeing after two thousand years.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ho parlato, hai parlato, ha parlato, abbiamo parlato, hanno parlato”
- the conservative *-t-* — “parlato · French parlé”
- “Ho lavorato” (“I worked”) — Ch. 5’s verb
- the old meaning — “I **have** a thing **spoken**”

Before you move on

What two pieces make the *passato prossimo*? (**Avere** + the **past participle**.) What is *parlare*’s participle? (**Parlato** ← *-ātum*.) What did *ho parlato* originally mean? (“I **have** [a thing] **spoken**” — a **possessive**.) Why can the participle agree? (It was an **adjective** describing the object.) Next: the other Italian past, and where it still lives.

15.2 parlò — the past that depends where you are

Italian’s other past tense. Whether it sounds normal or bookish depends on **which part of Italy you are standing in** — the

clearest case of geography deciding grammar in this course.

You'll want to know: the remote past

	passato remoto	passato prossimo
he spoke	parlò	ha parlato
they spoke	parlarono	hanno parlato
I spoke	parlai	ho parlato

Note the final stress: *parlò*, with the accent written. Compare Chapter 12's numbers — Italian marks a stressed final vowel the same way.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

parlò ← Vulgar Latin ***parabolāvit**, the plain Latin perfect, handed straight down. Which makes it the **same tense** as:

language	"he spoke"
Italian	<i>parlò</i>
Spanish	<i>habló</i>
Portuguese	<i>falou</i>
French	<i>il parla</i>

One Latin ancestor, four descendants — and four different fates in daily life.

Why it's said this way

This is what makes Italian interesting here:

region	everyday past
Sicily, much of the south	passato remoto — <i>parlò</i> is normal speech
Tuscany	both, with a distinction of distance in time
North	passato prossimo almost always; <i>parlò</i> feels literary

So the "correct" answer changes as you travel. In the north the *passato remoto* has retreated to books, exactly as French's *passé simple* and German's *Präteritum* did. In the south it never left.

What you've built: three retreats and two holdouts

language	simple past	status in speech
French	<i>passé simple</i>	gone — books only
German	<i>Präteritum</i>	retreating , especially in the south
Italian	<i>passato remoto</i>	split by region
Spanish	<i>habló</i>	alive (though Spain is drifting toward <i>he hablado</i>)
Portuguese	<i>falou</i>	alive

Three languages let a “have” compound push the inherited past out of conversation; Italian is the one caught **mid-process**, with the old tense still holding half the country.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “*parlò* ... **ha** parlato”
- the sisters — “*parlò* · *habló* · *falou* · *il parla*”
- the geography — “in **Palermo** ordinary; in **Milano** literary”

Before you move on

What is the ancestor of *parlò*? (***parabolāvit.**) What decides whether it sounds normal or bookish? (**Where in Italy you are** — everyday in the south, literary in the north.) Which languages kept this tense fully alive? (**Spanish** and **Portuguese.**) Which lost it entirely from speech? (**French.**) Next chapter: the verbs that take *essere* instead of *avere*.

Chapter 16

Being, Going, and the Past with Essere

16.1 essere — “to be”

You have known one Italian “to be” since Chapter 2: **stare**, from Latin *stāre*, “to stand.” Now meet **essere**, from Latin *esse*, “to be.”

You’ll want to know: the six forms

io sono	noi siamo
tu sei	voi siete
lui/lei è	loro sono

Italian normally drops the subject pronoun because the ending identifies the person: **Sono italiano** means “I am Italian.” One collision needs care: **io sono** and **loro sono** are identical. Keep *loro* when context would not make “they” clear.

Grammar Lens: one accent and two words

È with the grave accent is the verb “is.” Plain e is “and”:

- Marco **è** italiano. — Marco **is** Italian.
- Marco **e** Anna. — Marco **and** Anna.

The two words sound different enough in careful speech, but the accent makes the contrast unmistakable on the page. Never drop it from the

verb.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin	picture	Italian
<i>esse</i>	being or identity	essere
<i>stāre</i>	standing or state	stare
Italian kept both verbs. The next micro-lesson shows the surprising place where their histories overlap.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sono, sei, è, siamo, siete, sono”
- “Marco è italiano” — then “Marco e Anna”
- “essere — be; stare — stand/state”

Twice through: “Sono, sei, è — siamo, siete, sono.”

Before you move on

Give the six forms of *essere*. (**Sono, sei, è, siamo, siete, sono.**) What does the accent distinguish? (**È**, “is,” from **e**, “and.”) Which older verbs became *essere* and *stare*? (Latin *esse* and *stāre*.) Next: why both verbs share **stato**.

16.2 *essere* → *stato* — a borrowed piece

Italian kept both Latin “be” verbs as **essere** and **stare**. Now look at the piece they unexpectedly share.

Grammar Lens: one participle for two verbs

verb	past participle
stare	stato
essere	stato

Essere's own participle did not survive. Latin *esse* never supplied a useful one, so Italian filled the empty slot with *stare's* **stato**. A verb assembled from historically different roots is **suppletive**, like English *go* / *went*.

That shared piece creates a real ambiguity:

sono stato = “I have been” or “I have stayed”

Only the surrounding sentence tells you which verb is meant.

What you've built: three Romance solutions

The same Latin material took a different shape in each sister language:

language	result
Spanish	<i>ser</i> and <i>estar</i> : two verbs kept fully separate
French	<i>être</i> : one verb with old <i>stāre</i> pieces inside its forms
Italian	<i>essere</i> and <i>stare</i> : two verbs that share stato

Italian sits between the other two: less separated than Spanish, less fused than French. You do not need either sister language to use Italian; the comparison simply makes the borrowed piece visible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*stare* → *stato*”
- “*essere* → *stato*”
- “*sono stato* — I have been / I have stayed”

Twice through: “Two verbs, one **stato**.”

Before you move on

What is *essere's* participle? (**Stato**, borrowed from *stare*.) What can *sono stato* mean? (“I have **been**” or “I have **stayed**.”) Which language keeps the two verbs fully separate? (**Spanish**.) Which fuses

them most? (**French.**) Next: the two-stem verb **andare**, “to go.”

16.3 andare — “to go,” on two stems

Chapter 2 gave you **Come va?**, “How’s it going?” The **va** inside it belongs to **andare**, “to go.” Learn the whole verb before using it to build the past.

You’ll want to know: the forms

io vado	noi andiamo
tu vai	voi andate
lui/lei va	loro vanno

Past participle: **andato**.

The table has a visible seam:

stem	forms	history
vad- / va-	vado, vai, va, vanno	Latin <i>vādere</i> , “to stride”
and-	andare, andiamo, andate, andato	origin disputed; perhaps <i>ambitāre</i>

Notice that **vanno** belongs with **vado**, not with *andiamo*. The split is not “singular versus plural.” It is two old verbs patched into one modern paradigm — another case of **suppletion**, like *essere* borrowing *stare*’s **stato**.

Spanish shows the same kind of seam in *voy* beside *andar*. The comparison is a memory aid; the Italian forms above are the only ones you need here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vado, vai, va”
- “andiamo, andate, vanno”
- the infinitive and participle — “andare, andato”
- the Chapter 2 callback — “Come va?”

Twice through: “Vado, vai, va — andiamo, andate, vanno.”

Before you move on

Give the six present forms. (**Vado, vai, va, andiamo, andate, vanno.**) Which plural form belongs to the *vad-* side? (**Vanno.**) What is the participle? (**Andato.**) Which familiar question already used *va*? (**Come va?**) Next: combine **essere** + **andato** and make the ending agree.

16.4 sono andato — the past built on essere

Chapter 15 built the past with *avere*: **ho parlato**. You now know the other auxiliary, **essere**, plus the participles **stato** and **andato**. Combine them, then watch the participle’s ending change.

You’ll want to know: start with stato

sono stato	I have been / stayed
sei stato	you have been / stayed
è stato	he has been / stayed
siamo stati	we have been / stayed

The plural **stati** is the first clue: with *essere*, the participle describes the subject and therefore agrees with it.

Grammar Lens: motion, change, and agreement

Many verbs of motion or change of state take **essere**: *andare* (go), *venire* (come), *arrivare* (arrive), *partire* (leave), *nascere* (be born), *morire* (die), *diventare* (become), plus *essere* and *stare*.

Use the four adjective endings you already know:

subject	sentence
Marco	Marco è andato .
Anna	Anna è andata .
the boys	I ragazzi sono andati .
the girls	Le ragazze sono andate .

A woman therefore says **sono andata**, not *sono andato*. The ending agrees with the **subject**, in gender and number: *-o*, *-a*, *-i*, *-e*.

Why it's said this way

The participle began as an adjective: **Anna è andata** was “Anna is gone-away,” with *andata* describing Anna just as *stanca* (“tired”) would. French keeps the same agreement (*elle est allée*); German uses a similar auxiliary split but no agreement (*sie ist gegangen*). The systems developed alongside one another, but only the Romance sisters preserve this adjective fossil visibly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sono stato, sei stato, siamo stati”
- “sono andato” — then, as a woman, “sono andata”
- “andato, andata, andati, andate”
- the contrast — “ho parlato; sono andato”

Before you move on

Which auxiliary do many motion and change verbs take? (**Essere**.) What does the participle agree with? (**The subject**.) Give all four endings. (*-o*, *-a*, *-i*, *-e*.) How does a woman say “I went”? (**Sono andata**.) Why does agreement survive? (The participle began as an **adjective**.)

Chapter 17

Head and Hand

17.1 la testa — “the head”

If you have done the French chapter, you already know this word’s story. What is worth seeing is how much **less** Italian did to it.

You’ll want to know: the word

la testa — the head. Feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **testa** meant an **earthenware pot**, a shell, a shard. Roman soldiers’ slang used it for the skull, and **across Gaul and Italy** the joke outlived the proper word *caput*. (Only there — Iberia kept *caput*, which is why Portuguese and Spanish still say *cabeça* and *cabeza*.) Put the two descendants side by side:

Latin	testa
Italian	testa — almost unchanged
French	tête — <i>s</i> lost, vowels collapsed

This is the conservative-sister pattern this course keeps meeting. Chapter 11 had *acqua* against *eau*; Chapter 15 had *parlato* keeping the Latin *-t-* that *parlé* wore away. Italian holds its shape; French erodes. Say them one after the other: *testa* ... *tête*. Same word, ten centuries apart.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

French gave *caput* away almost entirely, keeping it only in *chef* and *chapitre*. Italian kept it as a **live, common word**:

il capo — the head (of an organisation), the boss, the chief.

So Italian has **both**: *testa* for the thing on your shoulders, *capo* for the person in charge. English borrowed the second one straight out of Italian — a *capo* in a crime family is exactly this word.

Also from *caput*: **capitale**, **capitolo** (chapter), and **capitano**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la testa”
- “ho mal di testa” — “I have a headache”
- the erosion — “**testa** ... **tête**”
- the pair — “la **testa** on your shoulders, il **capo** in charge”

Before you move on

Say “the head.” (*La testa* — feminine.) What did *testa* mean in Latin? (An **earthenware pot** — soldiers’ slang for the skull.) How does Italian compare with French here? (Italian kept it **almost unchanged** — the spelling is identical, the vowel opened; French wore it down to *tête* — the conservative-sister pattern again, like *acqua/eau*.) What did Italian do with *caput*? (Kept it as **il capo**, “boss, chief” — a live everyday word, where French kept it only outside the head-slot.) Next: the hand.

17.2 la mano — “the hand”

Italian nouns *tend* to announce their gender: **-o** is usually masculine, **-a** usually feminine. (Chapter 1 deliberately didn’t give you that as a rule — it told you to learn each noun **with its article**, and this word is a good demonstration of why.)

You'll want to know: the word

la mano — the hand. **Feminine**, ending in **-o**. Plural: **le mani**
— feminine, ending in **-i**.

Both halves are irregular. A masculine *-o* noun would pluralise in *-i* (*libro* → *libri*); a feminine noun usually ends *-a* and pluralises in *-e* (*casa* → *case*). *Mano* takes the feminine article and the masculine-looking endings.

Grammar Lens: five declensions

Italian inherited a system with **five declensions** — five families of endings — and flattened it to **three** productive classes: *-o/-i* (*libro/libri*), *-a/-e* (*casa/case*), and *-e/-i* (*notte/notti*, which Chapter 1 already gave you). *Manus* belonged to the Latin **fourth**, whose nouns ended in *-us* but could be **feminine**:

Latin		Italian
<i>manus</i> (4th decl., fem.)	→	<i>la mano</i>
<i>manūs</i> (plural)	→	<i>le mani</i>

When Italian dropped the fourth declension, *mano* was left with its old gender and an ending that now looks like it belongs to a different class. The word didn't change; **the system around it did**.

That is the general lesson, and it recurs everywhere in this course: an “irregular” word is usually a **regular word from a system that no longer exists**.

(A few others survive the same way: *la radio*, *la foto*, *l'auto* — though those are short for *radiofonia*, *fotografia*, *automobile*, which is a different reason for the same look.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin *manus* is inside many English words:

- *manual* and *manuscript*
- *manufacture* (“made by hand”)
- *maintain* (“hold in the hand”)

English took **manage** specifically from Italian *maneggiare*, which meant to **handle a horse**. Every modern manager is, etymologically, working in a riding school.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la mano, le mani”
- the breach — “**la** mano, feminine, ending in **-o**”
- the reason — “fourth declension, *manus*, feminine”
- “manage ← **maneggiare** — to handle a horse”

Before you move on

Say “the hand” and “the hands.” (*La mano / le mani.*) What rule does it break? (The **tendency** that *-o* is masculine — *mano* is feminine.) Why? (Latin *manus* was **fourth declension**, whose nouns ended *-us* but could be feminine; Italian dropped that declension and left the word stranded.) What is the general lesson? (An **irregular** word is usually a **regular word from a lost system**.) Which English word came from Italian here, and what did it mean? (**Manage**, from *maneggiare*, to **handle a horse**.) Next: the rest of the body.

Chapter 18

Four Verbs of the Mind

18.1 *pensare* — “to think,” which began as “to weigh”

You already drive one Italian verb family: drop **-are**, add **-o** / **-i** / **-a**, and leave the pronoun unsaid — *parlo, lavoro*. This word costs you nothing new in grammar, and it buys a whole shelf of English.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-voiceless** — the *s* after *n* hisses, never buzzes: **pensare** = *pen-SA-reh*, not *pen-ZA-reh*.
- **r-tap** — one tapped *r*, the same tap as in *parlare*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pensare comes from Latin **pēnsāre**, “to weigh out carefully” — itself from **pendere**, “to hang, to weigh.” Roman thinking was done on a balance: you *weighed* a matter. English inherited both the scales and the thought:

- **pensive** — weighing something over.
- **ponder** — from *ponderāre*, “to weigh,” off the same root through *pondus*, “a weight.”
- **pension, compensate, expense, dispense** — all money *weighed out*, back when coin was measured rather than counted.

- **pendant, pending, suspend** — the hanging half of *pendere*.

Italian did something quietly remarkable with this one verb: it inherited it **twice**. *Pēnsāre* came down through ordinary speech, worn smooth, as **pesare**, “to weigh” — and it was later lifted a second time straight off the Latin page, unworn, as **pensare**, “to think.” One Latin verb, two Italian words, two meanings. *Parlare* had no such double; it arrived once, from *parabolāre*.

Grammar Lens: the same three endings

Nothing new to learn — put *pensare* beside a verb you have:

person	<i>parlare</i>	<i>pensare</i>
(io)	parlo	penso
(tu)	parli	pensi
(lui/lei)	parla	pensa

To say what you are thinking *about*, Italian uses **a**, the same little word that carries *abito a Roma*:

Penso a Roma. — I’m thinking about Rome.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pensare” — *pen-SA-reh*, hissing *s*
- “penso, pensi, pensa” — no pronoun spoken
- the trio — “parlo, lavoro, penso”
- “Penso a Roma.”
- “pensare” then English “pensive, pension, compensate”

Before you move on

What did *pēnsāre* mean? (**To weigh out** — from *pendere*, “to hang, to weigh.”) Name two English cousins. (*Pensive, pension, compensate, expense, ponder.*) Which two Italian words came from that one Latin verb, and how do they differ? (*Pesare*, “to weigh,” worn down

through speech; *pensare*, “to think,” taken later off the page.) Give the three singular forms. (*Penso, pensi, pensa.*) And which Latin verb gave *parlare*? (*Parabolāre.*)

18.2 capire — “to understand,” which began as “to grab”

Every verb you have so far ends in **-are**. This one ends in **-ire** and grows an extra syllable in the middle — a family Italian has and Spanish does not.

You’ll want to know: the word

capire — to understand. **Capisco.** — I understand. (*ka-PEE-sko*) **Capisci?** — Do you understand? (*ka-PEE-shee*)

The second one is a question the way *Parli italiano?* was: nothing is added, the voice simply rises at the end.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

capire is built on Latin **capere**, “to take hold of, to seize.” An Italian who understands you has **caught** what you said — the picture English draws with *I grasp it*, using a different verb for the same grabbing. *Capere* is one of the busiest roots English owns: **capture**, **captive**, **capable**, **capacity**; **accept** (*ad-* toward + take), **receive** and **recipe** (*re-* back + take — a recipe is “take these things”), **except** (“taken out”); **occupy**, **participate**, **anticipate**.

Careful — a look-alike that is not a relative. Chapter 17 gave you **il capo**, “the boss,” from *caput*, “head.” *Caput* and *capere* are **two separate Latin words**. *Il capo* is a head; *capire* is a hand closing on something.

Grammar Lens: the -isc- family

Drop **-ire** to get *cap-*. A large group of *-ire* verbs push **-isc-** in front of the ending, but only where the stress falls on it:

person	<i>capire</i> →
(io)	capisco
(tu)	capisci
(lui/lei)	capisce
(noi)	capiamo — no <i>-isc-</i>
(voi)	capite — no <i>-isc-</i>
(loro)	capiscono

That infix is a fossil. Latin had verbs in *-ēscere* meaning “to begin to.” Italian lost the meaning, kept the syllable, and spread it over a whole class. **French did the same:** *finir* → *je finis*, *nous finissons*, where *-iss-* is this very *-isc-*. **Spanish did not** — its *-ir* verbs have no such infix.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Capisco.” then “Capisci?” — voice up at the end
- “capisco, capisci, capisce” then “capiamo, capite” — the infix drops out
- “Capisco l’italiano.”
- the pair that is not a pair — “il **capo** ← *caput*; **capire** ← *capere*”
- “capire” then English “capture, capable, receive”

Before you move on

Say “I understand.” (*Capisco*.) What did *capere* mean? (**To take hold of** — understanding as grasping.) Which two forms drop the *-isc-*, and where does that syllable come from? (*Capiamo* and *capite*; Latin *-ēscere*, “to begin to,” the meaning gone and the sound kept.) Is *capire* related to *il capo*? (**No** — *capo* is from *caput*, “head.”)

18.3 leggere — “to read,” which began as gathering

Italian has exactly **three** verb families, sorted by how the infinitive ends: **-are**, **-ire**, and this one, **-ere**. With this word you have met all three, and the *-ere* family carries a sound trap in its own name.

Sounds you’ll need

Italian *g* is **soft** before *e* and *i*, **hard** before *a*, *o* and *u* — and the spelling never warns you, because the letter does not change.

- **soft-g** — **leggere** = *LEDGE-eh-reh*. The *gg* before *e* is the *g* of English *judge*.
- **hard-g** — **leggo** = *LEG-go*. Before *o*, the same *gg* is the *g* of *go*.

This is the identical rule you met with *c* in **piacere** (*pya-CHEH-reh*, soft before *e*). One letter, two jobs, decided entirely by the vowel that follows it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

leggere comes from Latin **legere**, whose first meaning was “*to gather, to pick up*” — you gather olives, you gather firewood. From gathering came *picking out*, and from picking out came *picking the letters off a page*. That last step is the whole of “reading.”

The gathering family is enormous in English:

- **legible**, **lecture**, **legend** (“things to be read”), **lesson**.
- **elect** (“pick out”), **select**, **collect**, **neglect** (“not to pick up”), **elegant** (originally “choosy”), **intelligent** (*inter-* + *legere* — one who **picks between** things).

And Latin *legere* has a Greek cousin, **legein**, “to speak,” which handed English every **-logy** and the word **dialogue**.

Grammar Lens: the -ere family, and where the stress lands

Drop **-ere**, add **-o** / **-i** / **-e**. Note that third form: the *-are* family ended in *-a* there, and this one ends in *-e*.

person	<i>capire</i>	<i>leggere</i>
(io)	capisco	leggo
(tu)	capisci	leggi
(lui/lei)	capisce	legge

One more thing your ear needs. *Parlare* and *capire* stress the last syllable but one — *par-LA-re*, *ca-PI-re*. Most *-ere* infinitives pull the stress **back onto the stem**: **LEG-ge-re**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “leggere” — *LEDGE-eh-reh*, stress on the front
- the flip — “leggere” (soft) then “leggo” (hard)
- “leggo, leggi, legge”
- the three families — “parlo, capisco, leggo”
- “leggere” then English “legible, lecture, legend, elect”

Before you move on

What did *legere* first mean? (**To gather** — then to pick out, then to read.) Name three English cousins. (*Legible, lecture, legend, elect, collect, intelligent.*) Why is the *gg* soft in *leggere* and hard in *leggo*? (The **following vowel** decides — soft before *e* and *i*, hard before *o*; the same rule as *c* in *piacere*.) Give the three singular forms. (*Leggo, leggi, legge*.) And where is the stress in the infinitive? (On the **stem** — **LEG-ge-re**.)

18.4 scrivere — “to write,” which began as “to scratch”

Reading was gathering. Writing, in Latin, was **cutting** — and the verb is an *-ere* verb, so its present tense costs you nothing

new. What it does buy you is a past tense, because this is where two old Latin endings resurface.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

scrivere comes from Latin **scribere**, “to scratch, to incise.” Before ink there was a stylus and a wax tablet, and writing was a cutting job. English took the root wholesale:

- **scribe, script, scripture, scribble.**
- **describe** (“write down”), **prescribe** (“write before”), **subscribe** (“write underneath” — which is what signing was), **postscript.**

Now weld it to a word you already own. Latin *manus*, “hand,” gave you **la mano** — and the same *manus* sits in **manuscript** and in its Italian twin **manoscritto**: hand-written. That second half, *scritto*, is this verb.

Grammar Lens: the present, and two participles worth keeping

The present is the *-ere* pattern you already have: **scrivo, scrivi, scrive**. The past is where it gets interesting. Chapter 15 gave you the recipe: *ho* plus a participle, as in **ho parlato**. Regular *-are* verbs make that participle in *-ato*. These two do not:

verb	participle	with <i>ho</i>
leggere	letto	ho letto — I read
scrivere	scritto	ho scritto — I wrote

They look irregular and are nothing of the kind. Latin’s participles were *lectum* and *scriptum*, and Italian applies to them the same sound-law that turned *septem* into **sette** and *octō* into **otto**: a consonant cluster with *-ct-* or *-pt-* collapses into a **doubled -tt-**. *Lectum* → *letto*. *Scriptum* → *scritto*. The rule you learned counting to ten is the rule that builds these.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **All three verb families**, one from each: **-are** (*penso*), **-ire** with the infix (*capisco*), **-ere** (*leggo, scrivo*).
- **Four minds’ worth of Latin**, and every one of them

physical first: *pēnsāre* to weigh, *capere* to seize, *legere* to gather, *scr̄bere* to scratch. Italian did not invent abstract words for thinking; it wore concrete ones smooth.

- **Two look-alikes kept apart:** *capire* ← *capere* (seize), *il capo* ← *caput* (head).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four, in one run — “penso, capisco, leggo, scrivo”
- “ho parlato, ho letto, ho scritto”
- the sound-law — “*lectum* → letto, *scriptum* → scritto”
- “manoscritto” — *mano* plus *scritto*, written by hand

Twice through: “Penso, capisco, leggo, scrivo.”

Before you move on

What did *scr̄bere* mean? (**To scratch, to incise** — stylus on wax.) Give the two participles and use them. (*Letto* and *scritto* — *ho letto, ho scritto*.) Why do both end in doubled *-tt*? (Latin *lectum* and *scriptum*; *-ct-* and *-pt-* collapse to *-tt-*, exactly as in *sette* and *otto*.) Name the physical act behind each of this chapter’s four verbs. (Weighing, seizing, gathering, scratching.)

Chapter 19

Taking, Asking, Helping — and Mi Piace

19.1 *prendere* — “to take,” and the other Latin verb for grabbing

Chapter 18 closed with all three verb families in one breath — *penso, capisco, leggo, scrivo* — and with the point that each of those roots named a physical act before it named a mental one. Here is the fourth *-ere* verb, the one an Italian table asks of you, and its root closes that idea.

You’ll want to know: the word

prendere — to take, to pick up, to catch.

Italian also uses it where English switches to *have*: what you take at a table is what you have. Every noun here is one you already own:

Prendo il pane. — I’ll have the bread. **Prendo l’acqua.** — I’ll have the water. **Prendo il vino.** — I’ll have the wine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

prendere comes from Latin **prehendere**, “*to lay hold of, to seize.*” English is full of it:

- **apprehend** (seize a person, or seize a meaning), **comprehend** (“seize together”), **reprehensible** (“to be caught out”).
- **prehensile** — of a tail that grips.

- **prison** — from *prehēnsiō*, “a seizing”; **prey**, **prize** (“a thing taken”), and **surprise**, which is being *taken from above*.

Here is the pairing worth carrying away. Latin had **two** everyday verbs for seizing: *capere* and *prehendere*. Italian built **understanding** on the first — *capire*, catching what was said — and **taking** on the second. Two Latin hands, and only one of them is about objects.

Grammar Lens: the -ere present, and a participle that goes its own way

Nothing new in the present: **prendo, prendi, prende**.
The past participle is **preso**, and it does not double a *t*:

Ho preso il pane. — I took the bread.

A different Latin cluster, doing a different thing. *Scrĭbere* was “to scratch” and its *scriptum* was the scratched thing; that *-pt-*, like the *-ct-* of *lectum*, collapses into **-tt-**. *Prehēnsūm* had **-ns-**, and Italian drops the *n* for a plain **-s-**: *preso*. Two clusters, two outcomes, both regular.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “prendo, prendi, prende”
- “Prendo il pane. Prendo l’acqua. Prendo il vino.”
- “Ho preso il pane.” then “Ho scritto.” — two clusters
- the two hands — “*capere* → *capire*; *prehendere* → *prendere*”
- the four physical roots — “weigh, seize, gather, scratch”

Before you move on

Ask for the wine. (*Prendo il vino.*) What did *prehendere* mean, and name two English cousins. (**To seize**; *apprehend*, *prehensile*, *prison*, *surprise*.) Which Latin seizing-verb gave *capire*, and which gave *prendere*? (*Capere*; *prehendere*.) Give the participle. (*Preso*.)

Why is it not *pretto*, when *scribere*'s participle is *scritto*? (Its cluster was **-ns-**, not the *-pt-* of *scriptum*.)

19.2 chiedere — “to ask,” from a Latin verb meaning “to hunt for”

A third *-ere* verb, so the endings are free. This one comes with a spelling rule you have already met once, and a partner verb that looks like a blunt English one and is nothing of the kind.

Sounds you'll need

- **hard-ch** — **chiedere** = *KYEH-deh-reh*. Italian **ch** is always a hard *k*, never the *ch* of English *church*.

You met this in **mi chiamo** (*mee KYA-mo*). The job of that *h* is to keep the *c* hard in front of *e* and *i*, which would otherwise soften it. Italian spells the hardness in; English spells the softness in.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

chiedere comes from Latin **quaerere**, “to seek, to look for, to hunt after.” Asking a question is going looking for an answer, and English kept the hunt everywhere:

- **query, question, quest** — the plain seeking words.
- **request, require, acquire, inquire, inquest**.
- **conquer** (“seek thoroughly”), and **exquisite**, something *sought out*.

The Italian shape is a long way from *quaerere*, and the road is worth hearing: Latin *qu-* before a stressed *e* went to **chi-**. Now use it on something you can already name:

Chiedo l'ora. — I ask the time.

Grammar Lens: the present, and the second verb for asking

The present is the *-ere* pattern: **chiedo, chiedi, chiede**.

Italian has a second verb here, **domandare** — a plain *-are* verb: *domando, domandi, domanda*. Both mean “to ask”. *Chiedere* is the everyday one and leans toward asking **for** a thing; *domandare* leans toward asking a **question**, and sounds a shade more formal.

Careful — a false friend. *Domandare* is **not** English *demand*. It is from Latin **dēmandāre**: *dē-* plus **mandāre**, “to put into someone’s hand” — and *mandāre* is *manus*, the hand you met as **la mano**, plus *dare*, “to give”. English hardened that word into an order; Italian left it meaning simply “to ask”. Same root, more English: **mandate, command**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “chiedere” — *KYEH-deh-reh*, hard *k*
- the pair — “mi chiamo ... chiedere”, the same hard *ch*
- “chiedo, chiedi, chiede”
- “Chiedo l’ora.”
- “chiedere” then English “query, quest, require, exquisite”

Before you move on

How is Italian *ch* pronounced, and where have you seen it before? (Hard *k* — *mi chiamo*.) What did *quaerere* mean? (**To seek** — asking as hunting for an answer.) Name three English cousins. (*Query, question, quest, require, acquire, exquisite*.) What is Italian’s other verb for asking, and what does it **not** mean? (*Domandare* — **not** to demand; it is *dē* plus *mandāre*, “to put in the hand”.) Which word you already know is buried in *mandāre*? (*Manus* — **la mano**.)

19.3 aiutare — “to help,” and the word you shout

After three *-ere* verbs and the *-isc-* class that gave you *capisco*, back to the easy family: this one ends in **-are** and behaves exactly like *parlare*. What is unusual about it is the pile of vowels at the front, and the consonant Italian wore clean out of the middle.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aiutare comes from Late Latin **adiūtāre**, a strengthened form of **adiuvāre**: **ad-**, “toward,” plus **iuvāre**, “to help, to gladden.” To help was to move toward someone with something good.

English took it through French and kept the *d*:

- **aid** — the direct descendant.
- **aide**, and **aide-de-camp**, “camp-helper.”
- **adjutant** — an officer who assists; **adjuvant**, in medicine, something that helps a treatment along.

The three sisters split on that *d*, and this is the clearest sound-contrast in the chapter:

language	“to help”	the Latin <i>d</i>
French	<i>aider</i>	kept, plainly
Spanish	<i>ayudar</i>	kept, softened around
Italian	<i>aiutare</i>	gone entirely

Italian’s habit of dropping a *d* between vowels ran here to completion: *ad-iu-* became simply *ai-*. This is one of the places where Italian, usually the sister that keeps most, kept least.

Grammar Lens: the *-are* endings, and the shout

Drop *-are*, add the endings you have had since Chapter 5: **aiuto**, **aiuti**, **aiuta** — the run *parlo*, *penso*, *aiuto*, with *penso* keeping its hissing *s*. Say the *io* form slowly. Italian gives every written vowel its own moment: *a-i-U-to*, four sounds, stress on the *u*. Nothing is swallowed the way English would swallow it.

And there is a bonus in that form. Italian’s noun for “help” is also **aiuto**, identical in spelling and sound to “I help” — so the cry heard in

an Italian street, “**Aiuto!**”, is the same shape as the verb you have just conjugated.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aiutare” — *ah-yoo-TA-reh*
- “aiuto, aiuti, aiuta” — four vowels in the first one
- the shout — “Aiuto!”
- the *-are* run — “parlo, penso, aiuto”, hissing the *s* of *penso*
- the three sisters — “*aider*, *ayudar*, **aiutare**” — the *d* fading out
- “aiutare” then English “aid, aide-de-camp, adjutant”

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces make *adiūtāre*? (*Ad-*, “toward,” plus *iuvāre*, “to help”.) Name two English cousins. (*Aid*, *aide*, *adjutant*, *adjutant*.) Which of the three sisters lost the *d*, and which kept it? (Italian lost it; French *aider* and Spanish *ayudar* kept it.) Give the three singular forms. (*Aiuto*, *aiuti*, *aiuta*.) Which of your *-are* verbs began as “to weigh”? (*Pensare*.) And what do you shout in the street? (**Aiuto!**)

19.4 mi piace — the verb that runs backwards

Chapter 3 closed an introduction with **piacere**, “a pleasure,” from *placēre*. That courtesy is this verb’s **dictionary form**. Here it goes to work — backwards.

You’ll want to know: the word

mi piace — I like it. Word for word: *to me it is pleasing*. **Mi piace il vino.** — I like the wine. (*mee PYA-cheh*)

The *c* is soft before *e*, as in *piacere*. And notice what is missing: any word for “I”.

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

English makes the **liker** the subject: *I* like the wine. Italian has no such sentence — the wine does the pleasing. So **il vino** is the **subject**, hence *piace*, the ending you learned on *legge*; **mi** merely names who it pleases. The verb agrees with the **thing**, not with you:

what you mean	Italian
I like the wine	Mi piace il vino
I like the seasons	Mi piacciono le stagioni
I like reading	Mi piace leggere

One thing takes *piace*, many take **piacciono**, an infinitive counts as one — and in that third row *leggere*, the gathering verb, keeps its soft *gg*. To change *who* is pleased, change the word in front: **mi** (to me), **ti** (to you) — *Ti piace il vino?*

That *mi* is an old friend: **mi chiamo** is “I call *myself*”, **mi piace** “it pleases *me*”. One word, two jobs, neither “I”.

Careful. *Io piaccio il vino* does not exist. *Io piaccio* is real Italian — “I am pleasing” — but not what you wanted.

The shape is not unique to Italian. **Spanish:** *me gusta el vino*, on *gustāre*, “to taste.” **French,** on this very *placēre*: *le vin me plaît*.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **prendere** ← *prehendere*, “seize” → apprehend, prison; at a table, *I’ll have*.
- **chiedere** ← *quaerere*, “seek” → query, quest; hard *ch*; **domandare** is not *demand*.
- **aiutare** ← *adiūtāre* → aid, adjutant; the *d* dropped out.
- **The thread:** all four reach — for a thing, an answer, a person — and *piacere* reaches back, from the thing to you. Hence the inversion. Chapter 18’s *capire* reached too: *capere* meant to seize.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Mi piace il vino.” then “Mi piacciono le stagioni.”

- “Mi piace leggere.” and “Ti piace il vino?”
- “prendo, chiedo, aiuto”, then “mi chiamo ... mi piace”

Before you move on

In *mi piace il vino*, what is the subject? (**Il vino** — hence *piace*.) Say you like the seasons, and why the verb moved. (*Mi piacciono le stagioni* — many things.) Which Chapter 3 word is this verb’s dictionary form? (*Piacere* ← *placēre*.) Name the roots under the chapter’s other three verbs, and under *capire*. (*Prehendere*, *quaerere*, *adiūtāre*; *capere*.)

Italian pronunciation — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — each lesson gives the sounds its word needs. This page just gathers them. Italian is gloriously **phonetic**: once you know these rules, you can read almost any word aloud correctly.

The traps for an English speaker

- **Every letter is sounded**, and vowels are pure: *a* (ah), *e* (eh), *i* (ee), *o* (oh), *u* (oo) — never the English glide.
- **c** and **g** are soft (*ch*, *j*) before *e/i* (*ciao*, *giorno*), hard (*k*, *g*) before *a/o/u* (*casa*, *gatto*). **ch/g** force the hard sound (*chi* = “kee”).
- **gli** = the *lli* of *million*; **gn** = the *ny* of *canyon*; **sc** before *e/i* = *sh*.
- **z** = *ts* or *dz* (*grazie* = “GRAH-tsyeh”).
- **Double consonants are held longer** and change meaning: *notte* (night) vs. *note* (notes).
- **h** is always silent — it exists only to harden *c/g*.

Stress

Most words stress the *second-to-last* syllable (*giOR-no*). When the stress falls on the last syllable it is written with an accent (*città*, *così*, *caffè*).

Italian in the Romance family

Italian, Spanish, and French are all worn-down Latin. Italian stayed closest to the parent, so its *-ct-* became *-tt-* (*notte*) where Spanish went *-ch-* (*noche*)

and French *-it-* (*nuit*); and it kept final vowels (*giorno*, *notte*) that French dropped. The lessons draw these contrasts as they arise.